Little School on the Prairie: A Push for Structural Transformation

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August 26, 2025

Abstract

The one room school looms large in North American history, but we have little information on the role these rural schools played in economic development. Using linked full count census records from the early 20th century Canadian prairies combined with precise geolocations for individual households and schools, I examine the effect of the roll out of one room schools on children's education participation and later life outcomes. I find that geographic proximity played an important roll in education participation. Expanding to a difference in differences strategy exploiting the timing of school rollout, I find that a treated child who had a school constructed nearby is less likely to in agriculture as an adult, lives further from their childhood home, and has higher income. They are significantly more likely to work in a higher skill services occupation, including as teachers, as adults. Farm sizes in the areas that construct schools increase. This suggests that education access can act as a push factor for structural transformation out of agriculture in rural areas.

"And although many farmers would have preferred that their children remain on the land, most knew it would prove impossible. The best they could do was to endow them with education to be mobile."

Goldin and Katz (2000)

1 Introduction

The one room school house is a quintessential part of the American mythos. These schools, typically rural, ungraded, teaching children between the ages of 5-14 were common in the United States but the evidence we have for their impacts is contradictory. One line of

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†JEL Codes: I25, R12, N31

reasoning argues that one room schools had low education quality and had lower returns than other forms of schooling (Goldin and Katz 2000; Lachanski 2024). On the other hand one room schools acted as an input for later education (Goldin and Katz 2008), allowed communities to tailor education to local conditions (Dippel and Ottinger 2020), and that early forms of education were important to increase human capital mobility (Althoff, Gray, and Reichardt 2025). What were the impacts of one room schools on the rural children and communities they served? And is there any truth to the idea that an educated child is more likely to leave the farm?

This paper answers this question by analyzing the rollout of one room schools in the western Canadian prairies at the start of the 20th century. The Canadian prairies are most similar geographically and culturally to the American Midwest to the south. Throughout both regions one room schools became the primary form of education in rural areas. The Canadian context offers a key advantage over the United States and other rural areas: the widespread use of legal land descriptions (survey boundaries) as addresses in census and other government records. As a result it is possible to geolocate both historical school locations and household locations to land section (1 mile square parcel). This allows for the estimation of the effects of school construction on individuals at a level geographic precision not possible in other historical datasets.

I first establish that geographic proximity strongly influenced the decision to attend school. In the cross section children adjacent to a school attend 3/4 of a month more per year, and are 3 percentage points more likely to read than children greater than 5km away from the nearest school. The distance to school is likely to be endogenous as parents could sort to locate nearer to the school. Assembling a panel of school openings, I therefore exploit the timing of school construction relative to the age of individual children. Linking together waves of the Canadian census and estimating a Difference in Differences in the style of Duflo (2001), I find that school construction decreased the likelihood of working in agriculture as an adult by 2.9pp, led to migration further away from home by 15.3%, and increased incomes by 11.8%. These results suggest that education expansions can act as a push factor for structural transformation in rural areas.

Expanding the analysis I find that children exposed to school are more likely to enter high skill service sector occupations and are less likely to enter low skill service sector occupations. Children with access to school are significantly more likely to become teachers themselves. Surprisingly there is no change in the likelihood of entering manufacturing occupations as would typically be expected during structural transformations. This suggests that changes in the composition of labor supply, relative to the typical forces of structural transformation coming from improved agricultural productivity and the decline for agricultural goods, might be driving a different type of structural transformation that we typically find in the literature. The expansion of education access also drives an increase in average farm sizes of 5.2%, nearly identical to the rate of children leaving agriculture as adults.

This paper fits in with four strands of literature. The first is the long literature on the expansion of education in the United States and Canada. This paper is most closely related to Goldin and Katz (2000) which estimates the returns to education in Iowa starting in 1915, and Schaede (2021) which shows that areas with poorer funding for schools remained more agricultural for longer. In methodology this paper is closest to Nencka, Karger, and Alison (2025) which examines the expansion of high schools in the United States. Dippel and

Ottinger (2020) argues that one room schools allowed for close customization to community needs, while Lachanski (2024) argues that the rural education advantage argued in Goldin and Katz (2008) doesn't exist due to lower education quality in one room schools. A recent study by Althoff, Gray, and Reichardt (2025) argues that educational expansion were a key component of increased economic mobility in the United States between 1850 and 1950, further supported by Card et al. (2022) and Card, Domnisoru, and Taylor (2022). Finally MacKinnon and Minns (2009) provides some of the little Canadian evidence on schooling and the consolidation of one room schools. Relative to these papers this is the first to isolate plausibly exogenous variation in schooling access in this time period to explore it's impact.

The second strand of literature this paper contributes to is on education and structural transformation. Caselli and Coleman II (2001) propose that the complementarity of human capital with non-agricultural production could lead to migration out of agriculture, and idea expanded on by Porzio, Rossi, and Santangelo (2022). Gauthier, Molina, and Nyshadham (2025) builds a dynamic version of Gibbons, Katz, and Lemieux (2005) to show that learning about own ability determines sector choice. A long line of literature also things about the productivity effects of selection into and out of agriculture including Lagakos and Waugh (2013) and Lagakos and Shu (2023). Additionally, this paper speaks to the complementarity between skills and different production technology as in Goldin (1998). A long development literature also finds evidence that education causes an exit from agriculture (Duflo 2004; Akresh, Halim, and Kleemans 2023; Cox 2025). This paper is among the first to show that the same mechanisms of structural transformation applied to now developed economies in the past.

Although this paper focuses on the development of the Canadian west, the geographic and institutional features are very similar to the United States. There has been a growing interest and use of homestead records in the United States including Smith (2022), Mattheis and Raz (2019), and Leonard and Kogelmann (2022). There is an older literature on the roll of surveying systems in Libecap and Lueck (2011) and Hornbeck (2010), and later work on the dust bowl, dryfarming, tractors, and farm size as in Hansen and Libecap (2004), Libecap and Hansen (2000), Hornbeck (2012), French (2022), Lew and Cater (2018) and Hornbeck (2022). There is also work that looks a city formation and rural hinterlands in Nagy (2023) and Bagagli (2023). Relative to these papers, this is the first paper to geolocate entire rural census populations.

Finally this paper relates to the literature on census linking. The census linking literature features two main methodologies: deterministic linking as in Abramitzky, Boustan, and Eriksson (2012), Abramitzky, Boustan, and Eriksson (2014), Feigenbaum (2016), Abramitzky, Mill, and Pérez (2020), Abramitzky et al. (2024), and probabilistic linking as in Antonie et al. (2014), Antonie et al. (2020), Price et al. (2021), Helgertz et al. (2022), Buckles et al. (2023). M. J. Bailey et al. (2020) offers a broad criticism of this literature, and J. Feigenbaum, Helgertz, and Price (2023) discusses the role of training data in these systems. Relative to this literature, this paper is the first to do a full count linking of later waves of the Canadian census including the 1931 census and the census of the prairie provinces.

2 Historical Background

2.1 Western Expansion

After the end of the American Civil War and the acquisition of Alaska, the Canadian Government also desired to expand territory westward (Lambrecht 1991). To accomplish this the Canadian government acquired Rupert's Land and the North-West Territories in 1870 from the Hudson's Bay Company. To further expand, British Columbia entered confederation with Canada in 1871, under the condition that a railway be constructed to the west coast from the east coast no later than 1881 (completed in 1885). The railway would simultaneously link the opposite sides of the dominion, while allowing settlers into the fertile prairies.

To enable settlement existing claims on prairie land has to be resolved. The Canadian government signed seven major treaties between 1871 and 1877 across the prairies to extinguish indigenous land title (Lambrecht 1991). The exact contents of these "Numbered Treaties" varied, but throughout they established reserves for indigenous people, administered by the Indian Act. The second group of claimants was the Métis, people who were the result of intermarriage between indigenous and european parents, who were granted 1.4 million acres under the Manitoba Act of 1870 and later lands in the North West Territories in 1885. The settling of Métis land claims was a source of continuous error, with repeated issuance of scrip which could be redeemed for land as late as 1925 (Lambrecht 1991). The overwhelming motivation behind the settling of indigenous and Métis land claims was to extinguish any claims that would impede settlement and risk the establishment of Canadian sovereignty [1].

Non reserve land would then be administered by the Dominion Lands Act in 1872 (Lambrecht 1991). The act laid out a survey for lands in Manitoba, the North-West Territories (to largely become Alberta and Saskatchewan in 1905), and later the railway belt and peace river block in British Columbia. Based on the Public Land Survey System in the United States, the Dominion Land Survey would both measure and allocate land across western Canada, and remains largely in place as of writing as the dominant way to describe parcels of land.

2.2 Schools

Upon the completion of the Canadian Pacific Railway in 1885, widespread settlement of the Canadian prairies began. As the prairies were settled and the number of children increased there was increased demand for schools, a need that was filled by one room schools which dotted the prairies.

The system for establishing schools was initially envisioned in the North-West Territories Act of 1875, but was repeatedly refined over the coming decades (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). A school would be established when a group of three taxpayers petitioned the

1. Prime Minister John A. MacDonald would defend his role as minister of the interior with regards to Métis land claims stating "Whether they had any right to those lands or not was not so much the question as it was a question of policy to make an arrangement with the inhabitants of that Province ... in order to introduce law and order there and assert the sovereignty of the Dominion" (Lambrecht 1991)

territorial, later provincial government, for the formation of a school district with a set of proposed boundaries (Baergen 2005). The districts had a maximum size which varied from 36 square miles in 1881, later to 25 square miles in 1887 (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006), and later decreased to 16-20 square miles (Baergen 2005), with a minimum number of children and ratepayers in the area (Baergen 2005). The government would approve the proposed boundary, select a location for the school, then organize a meeting a vote of the ratepayers to approve the school district (Baergen 2005). There were often issues with overlapping boundaries of school districts and the need to fill in holes between existing districts (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006; Saskatchewan Department of Education 1906, 1907, 1908, 1910, 1911, 1912, 1914). Funding for the school came from a combination of government grants and local property taxes (Baergen 2005; Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006).

The curriculum in one room schools was basic, and consisted of the three R's: Reading, Writing, and Arithmetic (One Room School Project, n.d.). Teachers were accredited by provincial governments and hired by the school districts. Throughout the early 1900's the expansion of schooling was rapid, giving rise to the motto "A New School Everyday for Twenty Years" in 1900 (One Room School Project, n.d.). As a result there was often significant teacher shortages and rapid turnover, as a teacher would stay for a year in a rural community before leaving (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). Although initially instruction was entirely in English, the Saskatchewan government later encouraged some teaching in other languages to encourage ethnic communities to integrate (Saskatchewan Department of Education 1906, 1907, 1908, 1910, 1911, 1912, 1914).

Despite being public schools, religious instruction was included in education. Canada's education system was defined on Protestant vs Catholic lines. This conflict resulted in different institutions depending on the province. In Manitoba publicly funded schools allowed for half an hour of religious instruction at the end of each day. In Alberta and Saskatchewan a system of public and separate schools allowed the religious minority in an area to establish their own school if desired (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). A detailed discussion of the role of religious education can be found in section 7.3. While religious education is an important feature of Canadian education, only 0.6% of schools in Alberta and Saskatchewan are separate in 1911. The handling of separate schools is unlikely the affect the results.

2.3 Surveying

The Dominion Land Survey uses a regular hierarchical pattern to survey land. The base unit of land is a township, consisting of an area 6 miles by 6 miles. The location of each township is defined by three values, the township number, range number, and meridian. Township numbers give the north-south position, start at the southern border of Canada on the 49th parallel, and count up as one proceeds north. Range numbers start at the Prime Meridian (approximately 97° 27'), and increase as one moves west. Range numbers reset as after crossing one of six meridians. Any position in the east-west direction is therefore defined by a range number, and the position of the range relative to the meridians. For example, a township could be located by 5-23-W2, or the 5th township, 23rd range, west of the second meridian. Figure 1 shows the extent of the Dominion Land System in western Canada.

Each 6 mile by 6 mile township is further subdivided in 36 sections, which is further

Figure 1: Survey boundaries for townships under the Dominion Land System. Each square consists of a 6 mile by 6 mile township. The red lines give the meridians. Each township can be uniquely identified by a township number, giving the north-south direction, and a range number plus position relative to a meridian, giving the east-west direction.

Map: Index to townships in Manitoba, Saskatchewan, Alberta and British Columbia showing the townships for which official and preliminary plans have been issued to January 1st, 1929. Topographical Survey of Canada, Department of the Interior. Compiled, drawn and printed by the Topographical Survey of Canada, Ottawa. [cartographic material]
Source: Library and Archives Canada/Maps, plans and charts/NMC43265

split into four quarter sections. Each section is numbered 1 through 36, starting in the lower right hand corner. Figure 2 shows an example of how sections are laid out within townships. Between each section is a road allowance of 90 feet, although this was decreased to 66 feet and only between every second section horizontally after 1881. The road allowances is an important reason why grid of land parcels remains largely in place today (Lambrecht 1991).

Within a township land was largely allocated between four parties, and although land policy changed over time the main pattern was largely established by the 1881 Dominion Lands Regulations Lambrecht (1991). Odd numbered sections, excluding 11 and 29, were reserved for land grants for railway companies to incentivize railway construction. In addition a small number of colonization companies could purchase and then resell land for the purposes of settlement. Even numbered sections, with the exception of 8 and most of 26 were sold as homesteads. Homesteaders were granted entry to a quarter section for a minimal fee, and after three years of cultivation and residence would be granted the title to the land. Sections 11 and 29 were reserved for the purpose of funding local schools, although the funds generated were pooled at the federal level and then redistributed to the provincial and territorial governments. Sections 8 and three quarters of section 26, and the entirety of section 26 every fifth township in the agricultural parts of the west were granted to the Hudson's Bay Company in exchange for their surrender of Rupert's Land and the North-West Territories in 1870. Details on the allocation process of land can be found in section 7.2 of the appendix.

3 Data

3.1 Census Records

The primary data source for this paper comes from the Canadian complete count census records for 1911, 1921, and 1931, and the census of prairie provinces in 1906[2]. The population of interest is individuals who lived in Manitoba and the portion of the Northwest Territories which became Alberta and Saskatchewan, starting in 1901. Census records for 1901, 1911, 1921, and 1931 can be linked to Census Subdivision (CSD) level polygons which have been digitized (HGIS Lab, n.d.). Where needed in 1906 enumeration subdistrict centroids have been constructed from household geolocations. Some variables of interest like months of schooling and income are available are only available in 1911, 1921, and 1931, while other variables the section, township, range, and meridian necessary to geolocate households are only available in 1906, 1921, and 1931. A full description of which variables are available in which years can be found in section 7.4 of the appendix.

3.2 Linking

To track individuals over time, I need to link census records between waves. I implement the Multigenerational Longitudinal Panel (MLP) method developed at IPUMS to link individuals across waves of the Canadian census (Helgertz et al. 2022). The MLP method is a two stage probabilistic procedure. In the first stage only males are linked across census waves.

2. Data access provide courtesy of The Canadian Peoples (n.d.)

31 Railway	32 Homestead	33 Railway	34 Homestead	35 Railway	36 Homestead
30 Homestead	29 School	28 Homestead	27 Railway	26 HBC	25 Railway
19 Railway	20 Homestead	21 Railway	22 Homestead	23 Railway	24 Homestead
18 Homestead	17 Railway	16 Homestead	15 Railway	14 Homestead	13 Railway
7 Railway	8 HBC	9 Railway	10 Homestead	11 School	12 Homestead
6 Homestead	5 Railway	4 Homestead	3 Railway	2 Homestead	1 Railway

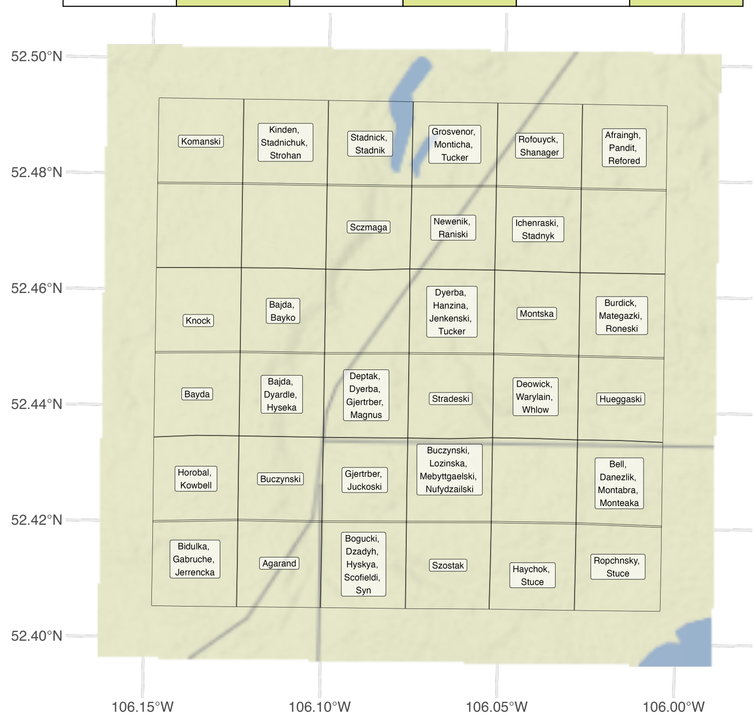


Figure 2: Top: Survey boundaries for sections within each township under the Dominion Land System. Even numbered sections, with the exception of 8 and 26 were sold as homesteads. Odd numbered sections with the exception of 11 and 29 were reserved for railways. Sections 11 and 29 were sold reserved to fund schools. Section 8, and three-quarters of section 26 (and the entirety of section 26 every fifth township) where given to the Hudson's Bay Company in exchange for Rupert's Land and the North West Territories. Bottom: A single township from the 1921 census: Township 40, Range 1, West of the 3rd Meridian.

In the second stage, the first stage links are used to infer links for family members who have been missed in the first stage. The second stage allows for both males and females to be linked. Linking is implemented using the hlink package (Wellington, Harper, and Thompson 2024). A more detailed discussion of this procedure can be found in section 7.5 in the appendix.

In both the first and second stage of the linking procedure links are determined probabilistically using a model trained on a set of known links. Unfortunately there is no currently available set of Canadian census links to train the matching model on. Instead I utilize the training data in the replication package of Helgertz et al. (2022) which links US census records. I train a logit model on the set of variables available both in the training data and those that can be assembled from the Canadian census records. This follows the best practice guidelines discussed in J. J. Feigenbaum, Helgertz, and Price (2025). Details on the variables used can be found in section 7.5.1 of the appendix.

Results on the match rates between Canadian census waves can be found in table 1. I'm able to match 26.69% of children between the 1906 and 1911 census waves, which declines to 16.27% across the 1906 and 1931 census waves when the difference in time between waves is larger. These results are broadly consistent with the literature, including Antonie et al. (2014) who claim a match rate of 24.22% when linking the 1871 to 1881 Canadian census.

Table 1: Match Rates for Canadian Census

	Total	**Matched**	**Children**	**Adults**	**Male**	**Female**
1906-1911	100.00	22.80	26.69	21.43	26.75	17.76
1906-1921	100.00	19.73	20.59	20.12	25.62	12.02
1906-1931	100.00	16.20	16.27	16.91	23.02	7.18
1911-1921	100.00	19.95	23.06	18.25	24.69	14.67
1911-1931	100.00	13.37	13.92	13.19	18.86	7.21

No automated linking method produces representative samples (M. Bailey et al. 2017). I therefore want to characterize which populations are more likely to be linked, and what effects the selection into linking are likely to have.

Section 7.5.3 in the appendix presents some results on the likelihood of being linked versus some characteristics of the individual. Linking rates are larger for the young, people from Ontario and the United Kingdom, wealthier families with larger livestock holdings, sons and head of households, and Protestants versus Catholics. In general, more prosperous individuals are more likely to be linked across census waves.

The MLP method utilizes geographic distance between the origin and destination as a linking variable. Including geographic distance is a tradeoff between distinguishing between more individuals and improving linking rates, while biasing the linking towards links where individuals don't move. In section 7.5.2 of the appendix I compare the results of the linking with the ABE method, which uses on time invariant factors, and find that changes in the match rate by distance are consistent with large improvements in match rate with little cost in increased distance bias. Newer versions of the ABE method also include distance as a linking variable, but only as a tie breaker (Abramitzky et al. 2025).

Based on the characteristics of linked individuals, the linking procedure is likely to bias my estimates towards zero. I'm more likely to link non-immigrants and the wealthy, who are the least likely to benefit from increased school access due to higher levels of parental human capital. Including distance as a linking variable improves the linking, while increasing the likelihood to link those who stay in rural areas and stay in agriculture.The outcome of interest is leaving agriculture, income, and migration. As a result I'm most likely to link those that remain behind, biasing my estimates towards zero. My estimates should therefore be interpreted as a lower bound. As a secondary measure the likelihood of a link is included as a control and observations are weighted by the likelihood of being linked. Weighting ensures that more weight is put on observations that have the highest likelihood of being correct.

3.3 Schools

Records of school locations[3] and opening dates come from three main sources. Alberta's schools are documented in Baergen 2005, and later digitized by the University of Calgary (University of Calgary, Glenbow Archives School District Database, Courtesy of Libraries and Cultural Resources at the University of Calgary). Saskatchewan's schools are best recorded in Saskatchewan Gen Web 2023, a genealogy website. Manitoba's schools came from Manitoba Historical Society 2019, which are largely based on the extensive archival work of Perfect 1978. In addition I supplement these records with annual reports from the Saskatchewan department of education (Saskatchewan Department of Education 1906, 1907, 1908, 1910, 1911, 1912, 1914).

While school opening dates and locations are nearly exhaustive in Alberta and Manitoba, the Saskatchewan records are inconsistent. I infer missing opening dates from the sequential numbering of schools in Alberta and Saskatchewan. Alberta and Saskatchewan shared education systems prior to 1905 when both provinces were created. Schools constructed prior to 1905 share a numbering system that allows the missing opening dates in Saskatchewan to be inferred from the Alberta school openings Baergen 2005. Details on the process of inferring opening dates can be found in section 7.6. School locations are also known less precisely in Saskatchewan. In cases where the school location cannot be geolocated to a land section, I utilize the township centroid or the centroid of a group of townships. Details on school locations can be found in section 7.7.3 of the appendix.

I assume that no schools closed during my period of interest. This is a reasonable assumption as the population of the Canadian prairies was rapidly expanding due to immigration, increasing demand for schools. The movement to consolidate one room schools largely occurred after my study period. Manitoba was the earliest to consolidate schools in 1905, but only had 77 consolidated districts by 1914 out of a total of nearly 1600 (Saunders, n.d.). Saskatchewan allowed for consolidation with an incentive grant in 1912, but the move was

3. I use the term "schools" and "school districts" interchangeably in this paper. Most school districts consisted of a single school, while a small percentage could consist of two schools. In a small number of cases a school district could be formed and then contract with a nearby school district to convey the students elsewhere. In 1913 there were 3,230 school districts in existence with 2,747 having a school in operation (Saskatchewan Department of Education 1906, 1907, 1908, 1910, 1911, 1912, 1914), although some of these would reflect new districts that had not yet opened their school.

highly unpopular (Baergen 2005). Alberta didn't allow for consolidated districts until 1913 (Sparby 1958), and experienced considerable resistance (Baergen 2005).

3.4 Geolocation

A unique feature of the Canadian prairies is the widespread use of Dominion Land Survey parcels and legal land descriptions as addresses. A legal land description consists of a section number, township number, range number, and meridian number, which define the location of a one mile square section. Quarter sections, defined by intercardinal directions, improve the resolution to a half mile square but are available inconsistently. In census records, colloquial, and other administrative use the legal land description was used as an address. The parcels defined by the Dominion Land Survey continue to be in use today, allowing for precise geolocation over one hundred and fifty years after the survey was established.

Table 2: Geolocation rates by census year for Alberta, Saskatchewan, and Manitoba. Exact geolocations are at the section level or in CSDs that are less than 1.5 miles in area. General geolocations are those that are at the township level or finer. CSD geolocations are at the CSD level. Splitting the geolocation rate by urban and rural households reveals that the majority of geolocations in both census waves are for the rural households.

	Total	**Exact**	**General**	**CSD**	**Exact (Rural)**	**Exact (Urban)**
1906	100.00	54.77	84.41	100.00	70.91	0.00
1921	100.00	65.97	69.61	100.00	83.89	36.35
1931	100.00	42.36	86.55	100.00	70.14	0.00

To geolocate households and schools I link legal land descriptions from census records and school records with GIS datasets of all land sections in the prairies. I merge datasets of land sections in Alberta (Government of Alberta 2020), Saskatchewan (Information Services Corporation (ISC) 2020), and Manitoba (Manitoba Government 2020). For households I locate to the nearest section, and identify potentially erroneous locations based on the location of neighbors and plausible paths that enumerators would have taken. For schools I locate sequentially, starting with the finest possible resolution. I first locate at the nearest quarter section, then section, then township. Detail on the geolocation procedure for households and schools can be found in section 7.7 of the appendix.

Table 2 gives the rate of geolocation across census waves. The top row gives the geolocation rates in 1906, the most important wave. I'm able to geolocate 54.77% of households in the prairies to a land section. This figure is an underestimate however, as in 1906 none of the urban households can be geolocated exactly. Looking exclusively at rural households I'm able to geolocate 70.91% of households. The results for later waves of the census are comparable.

Table 20 in the appendix gives the counts of geolocated schools. As of 1911 I'm able to geolocate 73.7% of schools to the exact land parcels, and 97.4% of schools to the township level. Details on school geolocation can be found in section 7.7 in the appendix.

3.5 Estimating Farm Size

Farm size is not available in the census records. Instead I construct an estimate of farm size by computing a set of Voronoi polygons around each geolocated household. I validate this estimated farm size against covariates in the 1906, 1921, and 1931 census. I find that the estimated farm size positively correlates with horse and cattle holdings. Estimated farm size negatively correlates with homestead status, consistent with homestead land sections being more fragmented between owners as documented in the US by Smith 2022. Details on the farm size estimation and validation can be found in section 7.7.4

3.6 Other Data

Railways formed the most common mode of transportation in the early 20th century. Railways were also critical for farmers to sell their crops (B. R. Hamilton, n.d.). To account for this I use a dataset of the location and year of construction of Canadian railways (Cartography office, Historical Canadian Railroads).

Agricultural productivity is also a key variable in determining the viability of an area. I make use of the FAO GAEZ v4 database FAO and IIASA (Global Agro Ecological Zones Version 4 (GAEZ V4)), utilizing the expected output density with the oldest possible time period (1971-2000), the CRUTS32 climate model, historical representative concentration pathway (RCP), rain fed water supply, low input level, and without CO_2 fertilization. I include data for expected yields for wheat, oats, barley, flax, which were the most common crops of the time, and reed canary grass as a proxy for livestock suitability. I note that the use of the crop suitability index has come under scrutiny for historical usage (Rhode 2024). The inclusion or exclusion of the index as a control has no significant impact on the results.

4 Motivating Evidence

To estimate the effect of school openings I follow the methodology of Duflo (2001), estimating the effect of school openings on a younger cohort of children who are able to benefit from openings, relative to an older cohort who are too old to benefit. To motivate this strategy I first want to establish 1) proximity to school leads to more education and 2) that beyond a certain age the effect of a school opening are small.

4.1 School Proximity

I first want to establish that proximity to school increases schooling. Despite the significant anecdotal evidence that geographic distance reduced school attendance (including quotes in section 7.1 in the appendix), there is no quantitative evidence that the distance to school affected attendance in this context. I observe the number of months of school attended(the flow of education) in full Canadian census waves (1901, 1911, 1921, 1931)[4]. I link children in

4. I do not observe the amount of education obtained (the stock) as adults in any census wave. This information is available in the 1936 Census of Prairie Provinces, which will be released in 2028 in accordance with a 92 year rule.

1906, where precise geolocation is possible, to 1911 where schooling is measured, and restrict to children who are likely living in the sample location in both 1906 and 1911.

Holding the 1906 locations constant and assuming the child has not moved, I then compute the distance to school in 1911. Details for the distance estimation and sample restrictions can be found in 7.8.1 of the appendix. I then estimate the following equation:

$$y_{ig} = \sum_{k=1}^{5} \beta_k \mathbb{1}\{d \in k_{1km}\} + X_i + \alpha_g + p_i + \epsilon_{ig} \tag{1}$$

where y_{ig} is the number of months of school that the child attended in 1911, or whether or not a child attended school in 1911. β_k is the distance to the nearest school in 1911 in $1km$ rings, with distances beyond $5km$ as the reference group. α_g is an enumeration subdistrict fixed effect, and p_i is the probability of a link being correct. X_i is a series of controls including the full set of interactions of sex, age, and birth order, birthplace, family livestock holdings, estimated agricultural productivity, whether the family lives on a homestead parcel of land, estimated farm size in 1906, and distance to the railway in 1911.

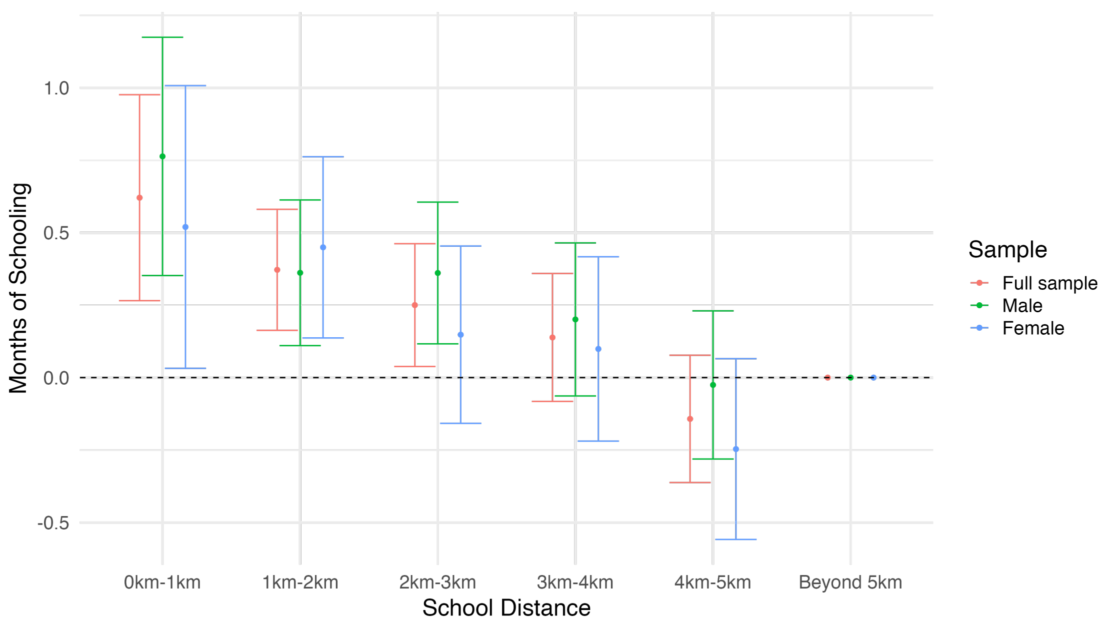
Figure 3 shows the estimated total effect of distance on the number of months of schooling in 1911. All coefficients are relative to children who are five kilometers or further from the school in 1911. I find that there are significant decreases in the months of school attended in 1911, with children immediately adjacent to the school attending for approximately 0.75 months more than children who are 5km or further away. The average amount of schooling for the sample is 4.9 months of school, implying a decline of 0.75 months is equivalent to a 15% decline. The distance effects are not statistically different for boys versus girls. Figure 20 in the appendix shows these results of decomposing these estimates into an intensive and extensive margin effect of distance, finding that there are similar intensive and extensive margin effects. These results are not driven by inclusion of controls as seen in tables 22 and 23 in the appendix.

There is a monotonic decline in the estimated effect size with distance, with the effect being statistically insignificant from zero for the full sample when children are in the 3-4km bin. These estimates align with the recommended school district size, which was for 16-20 square miles in Alberta (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). Assuming a circular district, this gives a radius of approximately 2.5 miles or 4km. This suggests policy makers of the time accurately judged the largest possible distance that a child would be able to travel to school.

School attendance may have declined due to distance, but that this may have had no effect on learning. To guard against this possibility I repeat the estimation in equation 1, but use the ability to read and write as an outcome variable instead of the months of schooling. The estimates show a similar decline in reading and writing ability with distance, with children adjacent to a school being approximately 3pp more likely to read than children further than 5km from the nearest school. The likelihood of a child reading is 86% in the sample, so a decline of 3pp is roughly a 3.5% decline in the likelihood of reading as a child.

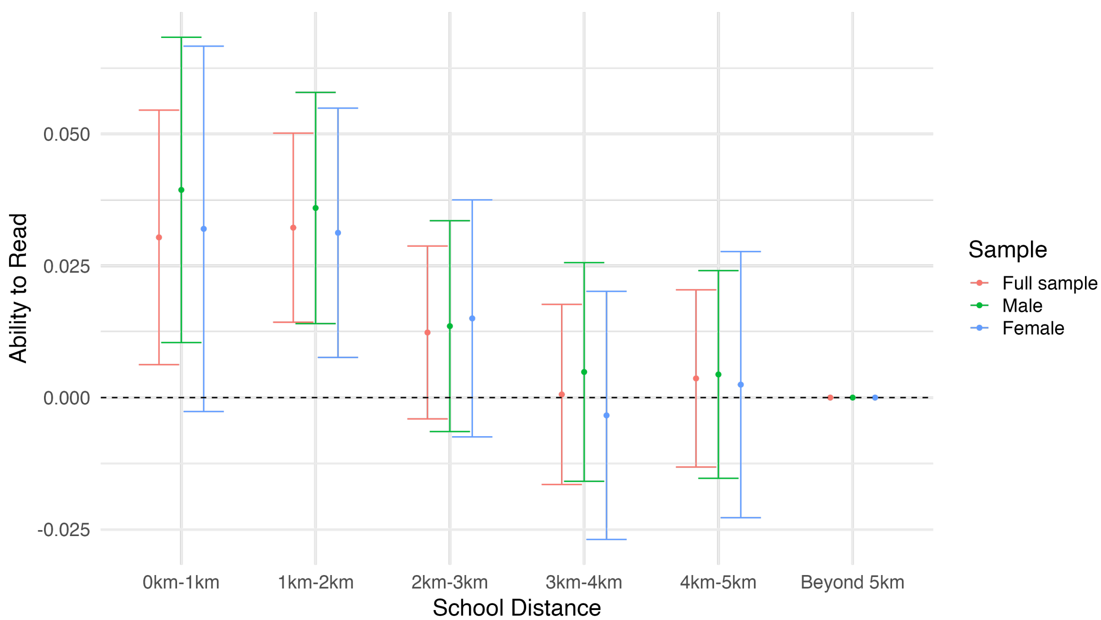
I do not interpret these results causally. Assuming that parents are altruistic towards their children, there are three main identification threats. First, highly motivated parents may lobby to have a school constructed near their household. Secondly, highly motivated parents may choose their location to be closer to an existing school. Finally, there is likely to

Figure 3: Months of Schooling versus Distance



Months of schooling by distance in 1911, in 1km bins. All coefficients are expressed relative to the furthest bin of 5km or more. Includes controls for the interactions of sex, age, and birth order, birthplace, family livestock holdings, estimated agricultural productivity, whether the family lives on a homestead parcel of land, estimated farm size in 1906, and distance to the railway in 1911.

Figure 4: Reading and Writing versus Distance



Reading and Writing Ability by distance in 1911, in 1km bins. All coefficients are expressed relative to the furthest bin of 5km or more. Includes controls for the interactions of sex, age, and birth order, birthplace, family livestock holdings, estimated agricultural productivity, whether the family lives on a homestead parcel of land, estimated farm size in 1906, and distance to the railway in 1911.

be some error in the measured distances to school. The first two forces would bias estimates upwards, while attenuation bias pushes estimates downwards. The overall effect is to cast doubt on distance as exogenous variation.

I take the stand that although the distance to school is endogenous, the timing of school construction relative to a child's age is exogenous. This assumption requires that although parents may have moved to be closer or further to an individual school, they could not manipulate the timing of school exposure for their children. This resolves the first two sources of endogeneity listed above as the direct distance to school does not determine exposure, but rather the timing of school construction in the general area. Any attenuation bias is less of a concern as it works against the main estimates.

4.2 Age and Schooling

The identification strategy relies on comparing those who have access to school versus those who don't, but comparing across cohorts instead of time. The key assumption is that beyond a certain age, children do not benefit from school construction. To validate this assumption I turn to the linked 1906-1911 sample. Figure 5 shows the months of school attendance versus age in 1911, split between girls and boys. Monthly school attendance increases between the ages of 5 to 8, is approximately flat between 8 to 12, then decreases beyond the age of 12. Children beyond the age of 12 are unlikely to benefit from school construction near them, as they are already starting to leave school.

Figure 5: Months of School versus Age

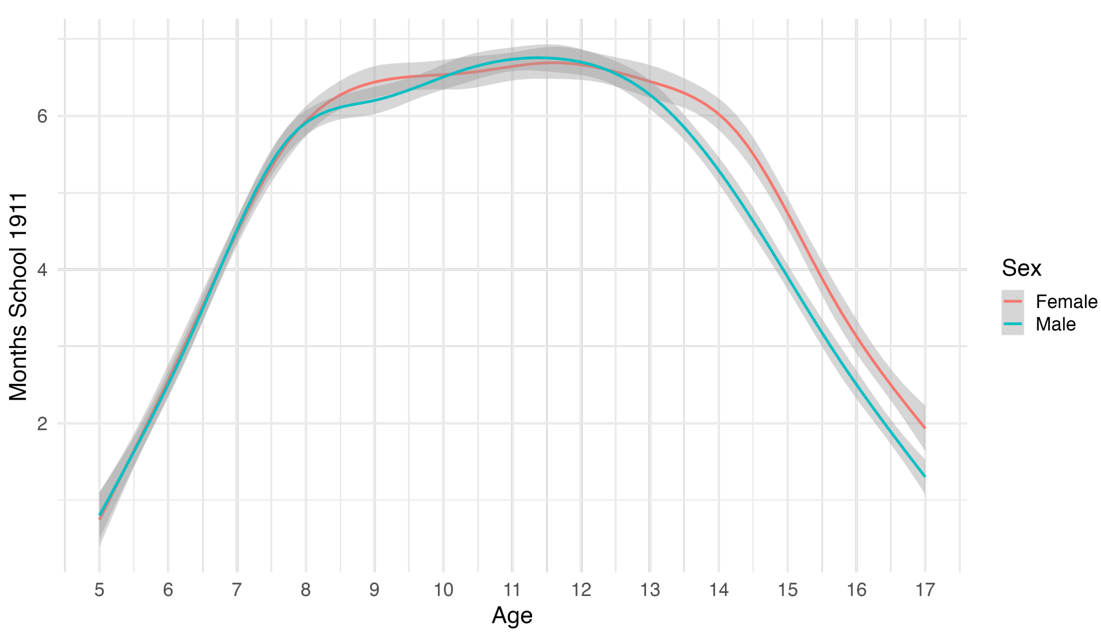


Figure 5 also highlights a noticeable gap in schooling between boys and girls after the age of 12. While girls continue to attend school for more than 6 months per year until after the age of 14, boys fall past this threshold at 13. The higher level of education for girls versus boys is attributed to the higher value of farm labor in rural communities, and was noted by school inspectors at the time (see section 7.1). The earlier decline in schooling for boys further justifies my identification strategy utilizing older cohorts as a comparison. The difference in schooling between girls and boys has been found in other contexts including the United States, but I am among the first to document it in Canada. A brief discussion of the topic can be found in section 7.8.3 in the appendix.

5 Difference in Differences

To estimate the effect of school openings I follow the methodology of Duflo (2001), estimating the effect of school openings on a younger cohort of children who are able to benefit from openings, relative to an older cohort who are too old to benefit. Until now the entirety of the results have been cross sectional, relying on variation within a single wave of the census to have an impact on later outcomes. I now extend the analysis by utilizing the rollout of schools over time to provide variation in school exposure.

The sample is boys in 1906 linked to the 1931 census when they are adults. Girls are dropped from the sample as most girls in 1906 are likely to have married by 1931, making matching unreliable due to changing last names. The 1906 census provides precise locations for rural households, while the assembled school data covers school openings in the period from 1871 to 1912. Assuming that migration is limited over short time periods, the geolocations will be most accurate around the year 1906. As a result I focus on changes to schooling exposure occurring between 1900 and 1906, utilizing data on school construction during this time period. This also coincides with the period before one room schools were consolidated.

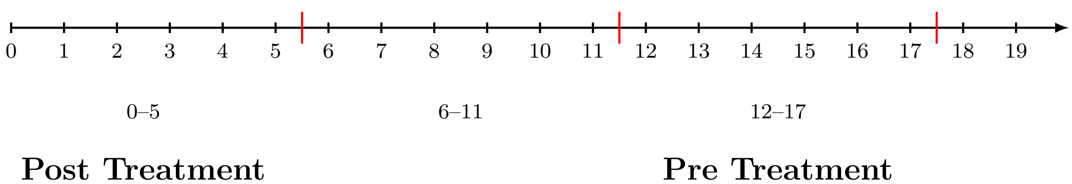


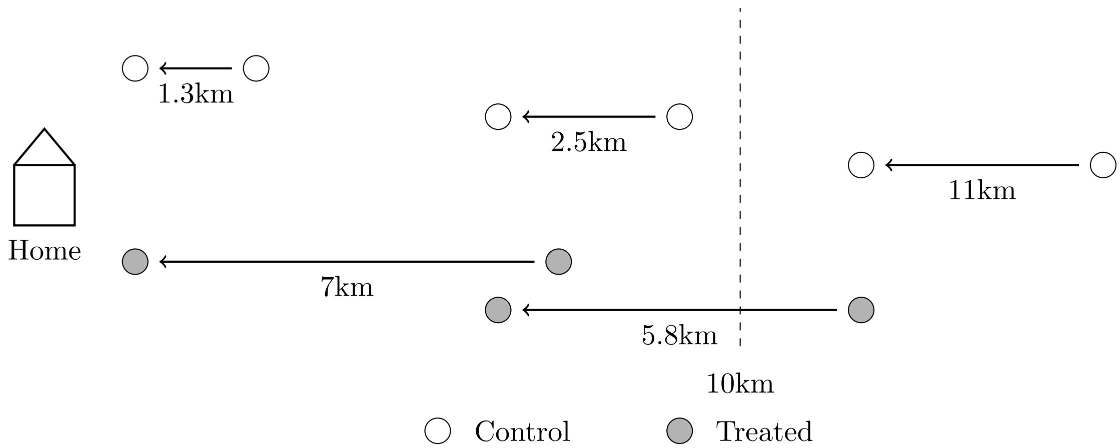
Figure 6: Ages and treatment timing in 1906.

Instead of using time, following Duflo (2001), I utilize the cohort as the time dimension. The primary cohort of interest is those between the ages of 0-5 in 1906, who will benefit from school construction. The cohort taken as the pre-period is those 12-17 in 1906, who are too old to benefit from school construction as demonstrated in section 4.2. As robustness I consider comparisons to other cohorts including $6-11$ and $18-23$.

Unlike Duflo (2001) where treatment intensity is defined at the region level, treatment here is defined at the individual level. An individual is considered as treated if the distance to school between 1901 and 1906 decreases significantly, while control individuals are those who did not see significant decreases. Distance is not included directly in the estimation equation due to possible endogeneity. Instead it is whether there are significant changes in local school availability that determine if a particular individual is treated.

Figure 7 shows how treatment and control are assigned to individuals. Individuals who see their distance to school decreased by 5km or more between 1901 and 1906 are treated, conditional on the final school distance being within 10 kilometers. This ensures that the exact distance is not determining the treatment, but rather whether there are significant improvements to school access in the area.

Figure 7: Treated and Control Individuals. Treated individuals (grey) see a decrease of more than 5km in their distance to school based on their home location, conditional on the final distance to school being within 10km. Untreated individuals (white) see a decrease of less than 5km or have a final distance greater than 11km in 1906.



The primary outcome variables are whether the individual is working in agriculture, income, and distance from childhood home in 1931.

Formally, I construct the estimation equation as follows. The comparison is between those who are in the 0-5 cohort ($t_c = \mathbb{1}\{age_{1906} < 6\}$) in 1906 and those who are 12-17 in 1906. An individual is considered treated if the distance to school decreased by 5km or more between 1901 and 1906, conditional on the final school being within 10 kilometers ($s_i = \mathbb{1}\{\Delta dist_{i,1901,1906} > 5km | dist_{i,1905} < 10km\}$). The estimation equation is therefore:

$$y_{icg} = \gamma s_i t_c + s_i + t_c + \beta X_i + \alpha_g + p_i + \epsilon_{icg} \tag{2}$$

where y_{icg} is the outcome of interest in 1931, s_i is the treatment, t_c is whether a person in the 0-5 cohort versus the 12-17 cohort, X_i is a series of controls, p_i is the estimated likelihood of a match being correct and α_g is a geographic fixed effect for the enumeration subdistrict.

This design also controls for other possible shocks we might worry could confound the results. One possibility is that regions that constructed schools could differ systematically from those that didn't. Enumeration subdistrict controls partly address this concern due to their small size (typically 4 townships, or 12 miles by 12 miles). Including an older control cohort ensures that other aggregate shocks at the region level are also controlled for. Changes in agricultural technology or agricultural prices which affect both young and old cohorts equally and are the typical forces of structural transformation will be controlled for.

A second set of possible shocks we might worry about come from shocks that are cohort specific. This is a particular concern with World War I participation which would affect the 12-17 cohort, who will be 20-25 and therefore prime military age in 1914 at the start of the war. Thankfully the design accounts for this, so long as participation in the war is not correlated with the likelihood of being treated by school construction. This could still be a potential threat if school construction encouraged more students to enlist in WWI[5].

5.1 Agriculture, Migration, and Income

I first examining whether an individual is working on a farm in 1931. Working on a farm is a combination of two groups. The first group is those listed as working in an agricultural occupation as defined by their occupation codes. The second group is those listed as labourers who are working on a farm as listed by their industry codes.

Table 3 shows the results. Starting in the simplest specification in column 1, I find that the interaction effect for school construction and cohort is -3.73pp, or a 6% decrease in the likelihood of working on a farm as an adult. The cohort effect is negative in this specification, indicating that the younger "post" cohort is less likely to be in agriculture as adults, but this effect disappears with the inclusion of controls. The school construction effect is near zero, suggesting that schools are not being systematically constructed in areas where children are more or less likely to stay working on a farm.

Columns 2-5 of table 3 include additional controls that may influence the results. Column 2 include controls for birthplace and birthplace of parents, leading to a decrease in the coefficient size. Controlling for birthplace is important to capture cultural differences in education. Column 3 adds in controls for homestead status, who are on average poorer, and livestock holdings, who are on average richer. Column 4 includes controls for agricultural productivity from the crop suitability indexes. Although birthplace controls impacted the coefficients, the inclusion of agricultural controls appears to have had minimal effects.

Column 5 of table 3 includes a control for the log distance to railway in 1906, and is the preferred specification. Railways were the primary mode of transportation at the time, providing both manufactured goods and a market to sell grain. I find that the likelihood of remaining in agriculture is positively associated with distance to the railroad in 1906. There is the possibility of interaction effects between railway access and school access. Instead I find that the largest effects from education come from households furthest from the railway as seen in table 25 in the appendix.

As a control I include the likelihood of a link being correct as generated by the MLP procedure. I also weight all observations by this probability. The coefficient on probability is a strongly positive. This indicates that an individual is more likely to be linked if they remain in agriculture. The estimates for the effect of school construction are therefore likely to be an underestimate of the true schooling effects if an individual is less likely to be matched if leaving agriculture.

The decline in farm work likely coincides with migration. Table 4 repeats the same estimation with migration distance as an outcome. I find that having a school constructed nearby increases the distance from home by 15.3% when using an arc-hyperbolic sine transformation in column 2 and 12.8% when using a log transformation in column 3. Both the 1906 census records and 1931 census records include the location information of individual households. I construct a binary outcome for an adult living on the same land section as they

5. A possible future step would be to link to the 1916 Census of the Prairie Provinces, which asked for military service.

Table 3: Farm Work in 1931

Dependent Variable:	Farm Work				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
School Constr. × Cohort	-0.0373**	-0.0268	-0.0285*	-0.0287*	-0.0289*
	(0.0169)	(0.0170)	(0.0170)	(0.0170)	(0.0170)
School Constr.	0.0085	0.0023	0.0031	0.0008	0.0012
	(0.0174)	(0.0176)	(0.0175)	(0.0176)	(0.0174)
Cohort	-0.0188**	-0.0113	0.0081	0.0078	0.0070
	(0.0093)	(0.0098)	(0.0098)	(0.0098)	(0.0098)
Log RR Distance (1906)					0.0204***
					(0.0047)
Link Prob.	0.4843***	0.4719***	0.4597***	0.4596***	0.4602***
	(0.0248)	(0.0252)	(0.0249)	(0.0250)	(0.0250)
Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fam. Bpl.		Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Homestead			Yes	Yes	Yes
Livestock			Yes	Yes	Yes
Ag. Productive.				Yes	Yes
Observations	14,701	14,701	14,701	14,701	14,701
R^2	0.07991	0.08576	0.09607	0.09741	0.09896
Dependent variable mean	0.62009	0.62009	0.62009	0.62009	0.62009

Clustered (Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Likelihood of working on a farm as an adult. School construction (treatment) is defined as 1 if the distance to school decreased by more than 5km between 1901 and 1906, conditional on it being within 10km by 1906. The post cohort are those who are 0-5 in 1906, as compared to those who are 12-17. Railway distance in the distance in 1906. Homestead is a control for the type of land parcel a family is on in 1906. Family birthplace are controls for own, father's and mother's birthplace. Livestock controls for family holdings of cattle, hogs, horses, milk cows, and sheep in 1906 as taken from the census. Agricultural conditions are for the agricultural productivity in wheat, oats, barley, flax, and reed canary grass. The link probability is a model derived probability of a link being correct from the MLP linking.

did as a child. Column 4 finds there is an insignificant decline (-1.22pp) in the likelihood of living on the same family farm, but the point estimate agrees with the previous results.

In all of the distance estimates the coefficient on link probability is significant; people who migrated further away are less likely to be linked. This is due to the inclusion of geographic distance as a linking variable. The bias introduced from linking will downward bias these estimates. They should be taken as a lower bound of the true effect of schooling on migration distance.

Table 4: Migration Distance between 1906 and 1931

Dependent Variables:	Migration Dist. (km)	Asinh Migration. Dist.	Log Migration Dist.	On Family Farm
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
School Constr. × Cohort	27.45***	0.1532*	0.1280*	-0.0122
	(10.31)	(0.0857)	(0.0737)	(0.0176)
School Constr.	-2.879	-0.0246	-0.0275	-0.0030
	(8.672)	(0.0803)	(0.0724)	(0.0161)
Cohort	-5.906	-0.1754***	0.0028	0.0397***
	(6.317)	(0.0505)	(0.0448)	(0.0096)
Log RR Distance (1906)	-4.339*	-0.0340	-0.0137	0.0110***
	(2.553)	(0.0232)	(0.0202)	(0.0040)
Link Prob.	-975.3***	-5.569***	-4.755***	0.5074***
	(27.84)	(0.1249)	(0.1060)	(0.0191)
Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fam. Bpl. + Homestead	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Livestock + Ag.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	14,701	14,701	12,977	14,701
R^2	0.28190	0.22393	0.24303	0.12290
Dependent variable mean	223.17	4.1938	4.0493	0.23624

Clustered (Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Distance from childhood home in 1906 versus adult home in 1931. Column 1 reports the effect on linear distance, which are highly skewed. Column 2 resolves this and reports the estimated effect taking the Inverse Hyperbolic Arcsine of the distances. To check if the presence of zeros is driving the results, column 3 reports the log migration distance. Finally Column 4 reports a binary outcome for if an individual is living on the same farm as an adult that they were as a child. School construction is defined as 1 if the distance to school decreased by more than 5km between 1901 and 1906. The treated cohort is those who are 0-5 in 1906, as compared to those who are 12-17. Railway distance in the distance in 1906. Homestead is a control for the type of land parcel a family is on in 1906. Family birthplace are controls for own, father's and mother's birthplace. Livestock controls for family holdings of cattle, hogs, horses, milk cows, and sheep in 1906 as taken from the census. Agricultural conditions are for the agricultural productivity in wheat, oats, barley, flax, and reed canary grass. The link probability is a model derived probability of a link being correct from the MLP linking.

One advantage of Canadian census records is that income is recorded starting in 1901. I therefore want to examine the income effects of school access. One concern is the selection process into reporting income in the census. Only employees were asked in the 1931 census to report income for the prior 12 months (Canada. Dominion Bureau of Statistics. 1931). The majority of farmers are self employed and therefore reported no income. The sample size for income is significantly smaller than that for other outcome variables, and reflects income conditional on being an employee, of which the majority are non-agricultural.

Table 5 shows this result. The baseline specification in column 1 reports a 9.72% increase in income for children who gained access to school. Including more controls leads to the preferred specification in column 5, which reports a 11.88% in income. As with the results for agriculture the likelihood of being linked decreases with income, these effects are likely an underestimate of the true income effect.

Enumerators where asked to only record the income of employees, but not all enumerators followed the instructions. Table 29 in the appendix reports income for all farmers, conditional on reporting, in the 1931 census. I find that farmers and farm labourers are amongst the lowest paid occupations. There is a clear hierarchy, with farming employees earning the lowest amount, own account farmers in the middle, and farming employers as the highest earners.

The results presented so far make use of the comparison of children 0-5 in 1906 to those 12-17 in 1906. This estimation can be repeated with other cohorts, creating an event study. This allows us to visually confirm that older cohorts do not have any impact from treatment, equivalent to the parallel trends assumption. I split children and young adults between the ages of 0 and 24 in 1906 into four age groups. The excluded age group is those 12-17 as in the difference in differences. The specification echos the earlier difference in differences specification:

$$y_{icg} = \sum_{k \neq \text{age}_{12} - \text{age}_{17}} \gamma_k t_k s_i + s_i + t_c + \beta X_i + \alpha_g + \epsilon_{icg} \tag{3}$$

with dummies for each cohort t_k.

Figure 8 shows the results. Income is positive and significant for the youngest cohort, with some evidence of pre-trends. The likelihood of working on a farm is negative only for the youngest cohort, with no evidence of pre-trends confounding the results. Relative to the 12-17 cohort, it is only the youngest cohort of 0-5 who sees significant benefits from school construction.

Two further robustness checks can be found in the appendix. I vary the distance threshold used to define treatment and control in tables 26 and 27, finding broadly similar results. As a further robustness check I alter the definition of working in agriculture by including other family members, counting if any family members works in agriculture. This sharpens the result from table 3, and is significant across all specifications with a marginal change in the point estimates.

5.2 Occupation

Knowing that people are exiting agriculture, what occupations are the switching into? The 1931 census includes information on the occupation that people held, and this information

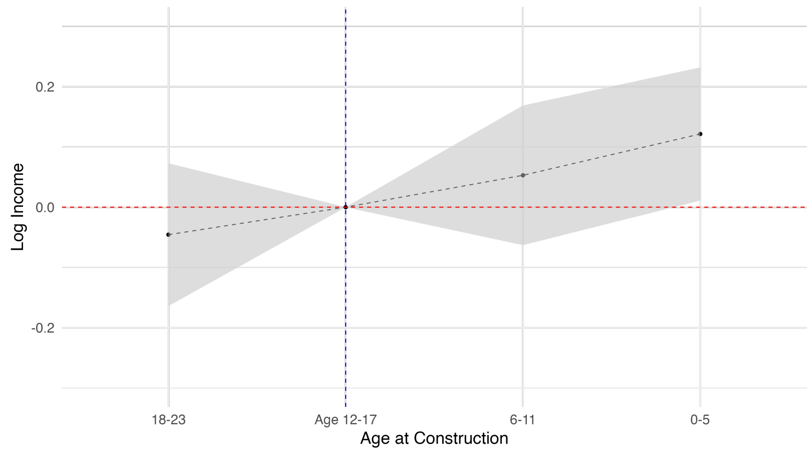
Table 5: Income in 1931

Dependent Variable:	Log Income				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
School Constr. × Cohort	0.0972*	0.1070*	0.1125*	0.1185**	0.1188**
	(0.0570)	(0.0587)	(0.0592)	(0.0596)	(0.0597)
School Constr.	0.0145	0.0083	0.0055	0.0081	0.0071
	(0.0544)	(0.0556)	(0.0563)	(0.0555)	(0.0552)
Cohort	-0.3048***	-0.2691***	-0.2622***	-0.2566***	-0.2551***
	(0.0278)	(0.0294)	(0.0305)	(0.0306)	(0.0307)
Log RR Distance (1906)					-0.0337***
					(0.0125)
Link Prob.	-0.2289***	-0.1851***	-0.1871***	-0.1914***	-0.1961***
	(0.0627)	(0.0626)	(0.0625)	(0.0629)	(0.0629)
Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fam. Bpl.		Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Homestead			Yes	Yes	Yes
Livestock			Yes	Yes	Yes
Ag. Productive.				Yes	Yes
Observations	5,651	5,651	5,651	5,651	5,651
R^2	0.15622	0.16427	0.16816	0.17310	0.17437
Dependent variable mean	6.5234	6.5234	6.5234	6.5234	6.5234

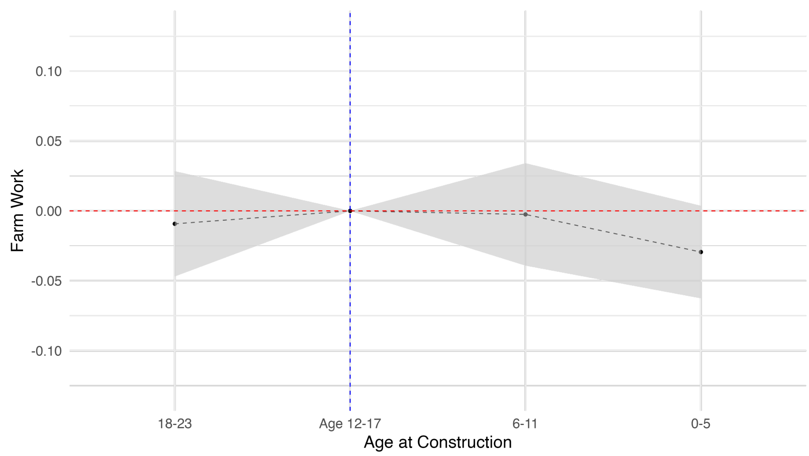
Clustered (Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Income as an adult in 1931. School construction is defined as 1 if the distance to school decreased by more than 5km between 1901 and 1906, conditional on it being within 10km by 1905. The treated cohort is those who are 0-5 in 1906, as compared to those who are 12-17. Railway distance in the distance in 1906. Homestead is a control for the type of land parcel a family is on in 1906. Family birthplace are controls for own, father's and mother's birthplace. Livestock controls for family holdings of cattle, hogs, horses, milk cows, and sheep in 1906 as taken from the census. Agricultural conditions are for the agricultural productivity in wheat, oats, barley, flax, and reed canary grass. The link probability is a model derived probability of a link being correct from the MLP linking.

Figure 8: Event Study



(a) Income



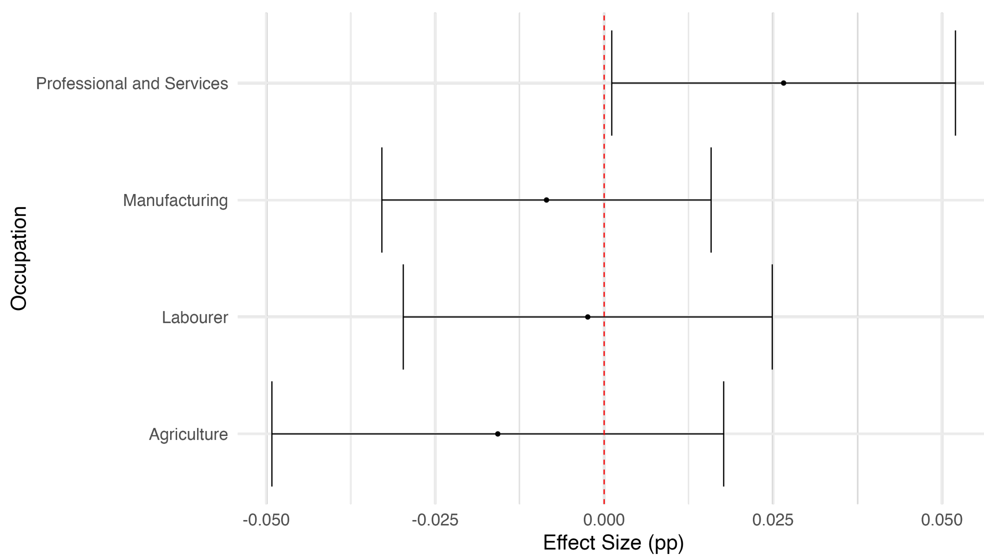
(b) Farm Work

Figure 9: Event study for income and engaging in farm work. School construction is defined as 1 if the distance to school decreased by more than 5km between 1901 and 1906, conditional on it being within 10km by 1905. The treated cohort is those who are 0-5 in 1906, as compared to those who are 12-17. Railway distance in the distance in 1906. Homestead is a control for the type of land parcel a family is on in 1906. Family birthplace are controls for own, father's and mother's birthplace. Livestock controls for family holdings of cattle, hogs, horses, milk cows, and sheep in 1906 as taken from the census. Agricultural conditions are for the agricultural productivity in wheat, oats, barley, flax, and reed canary grass. The link probability is a model derived probability of a link being correct from the MLP linking.

has been coded to six digit occupation codes using the HISCO definitions. I repeat the same Difference in Differences estimation strategy as above, but use as outcome variables the occupation held by different individuals.

Figure 10 shows a breakdown by the three primary industries, and a separate category for labourer. The estimate effect of school exposure is only significant for the professional and services sector, which is positive. Manufacturing and labour are slightly negative but insignificant. Agriculture is negative but insignificant, reflecting the inclusion of farmers but not laborers working on a farm in the earlier results. The positive result for professional and services is somewhat surprising given the typical pathway to regional development that goes from agriculture to manufacturing then to services. These results suggest that education expansions may bypass the traditional route through manufacturing. An alternate explanation could be the relative lack of manufacturing in the Canadian prairies, and phenomena also mentioned in Goldin and Katz (2000) in Iowa.

Figure 10: Primary Industry

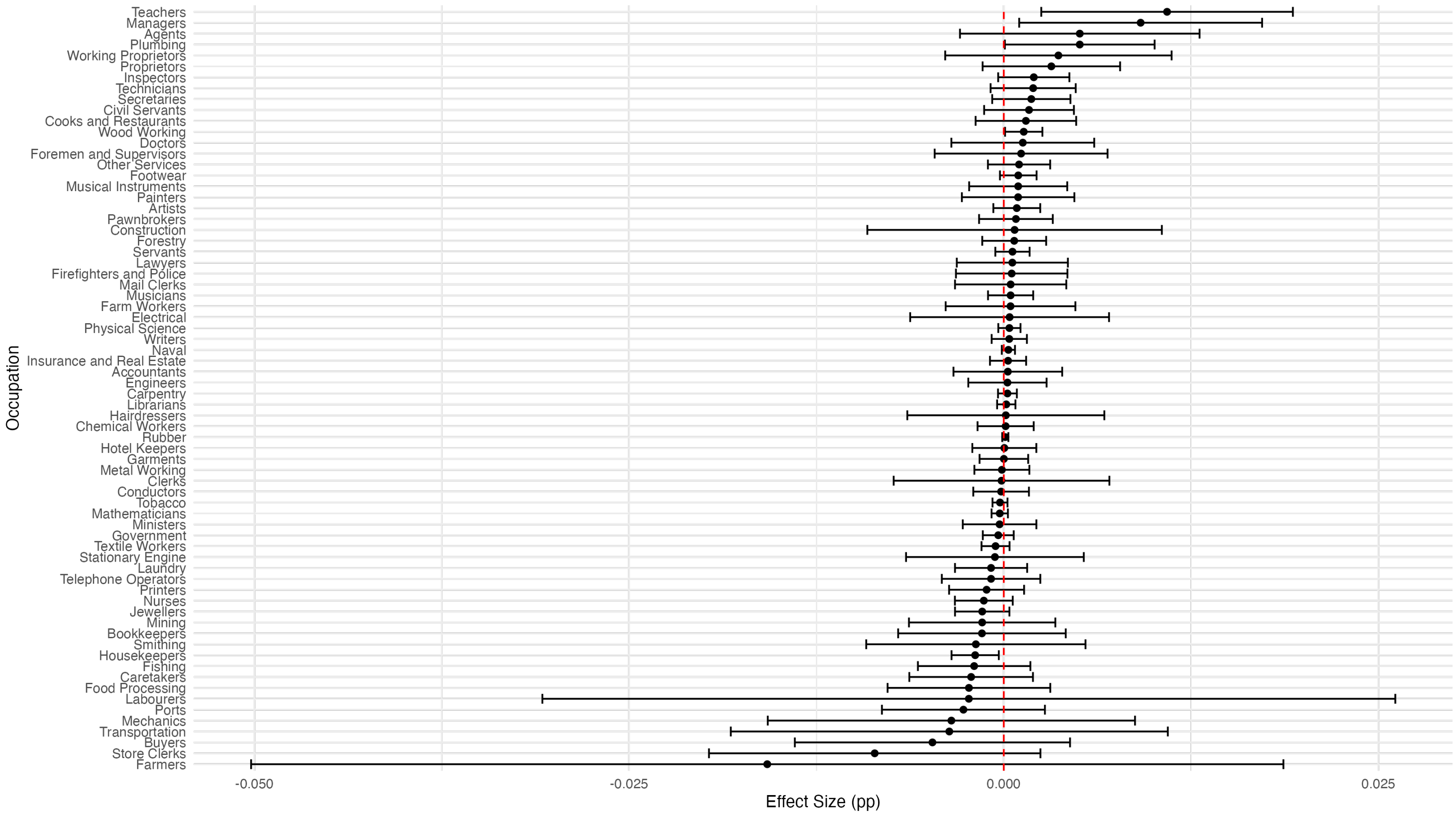


One digit occupation estimation. School construction is defined as 1 if the distance to school decreased by more than 5km between 1901 and 1906, conditional on it being within 10km by 1905. The treated cohort is those who are 0-5 in 1906, as compared to those who are 12-17. Railway distance in the distance in 1906. Homestead is a control for the type of land parcel a family is on in 1906. Family birthplace are controls for own, father's and mother's birthplace. Livestock controls for family holdings of cattle, hogs, horses, milk cows, and sheep in 1906 as taken from the census. Agricultural conditions are for the agricultural productivity in wheat, oats, barley, flax, and reed canary grass. The link probability is a model derived probability of a link being correct from the MLP linking.

I break down this further into two digit occupations, as seen in figure 11. In addition to the insignificant decline in working in agricultural occupations, there are insignificant declines in the likelihood of working as a store clerk, in transportation, or as a buyer. There is also a significant decline in the likelihood of becoming a housekeeper, although the magnitude of the coefficient is small. In general the occupations that see declines tend to be lower skilled occupations.

In contrast there is a marked increase in the likelihood of working in some higher skill occupations. There are significant increases for the likelihood of being a teacher and manager, both of which are high skill occupations that require education. Teachers were one of the few high skill occupations available in rural areas, it is reassuring that children who had exposure to teachers are more likely to enter this occupation themselves as adults. There are insignificant, but positive, increases for becoming a working proprietor who owns their own business, which would require entrepreneurial ability and is also likely to be higher skilled. There is also an positive but insignificant increase in the likelihood of becoming a plumber. This is somewhat surprising today, but in 1931 indoor plumbing was considered a luxury in the prairies (Dyck 2007), suggesting a premium for plumbers.

Figure 11: 2 Digit Occupations



Two digit occupation estimation. School construction is defined as 1 if the distance to school decreased by more than 5km between 1901 and 1906, conditional on it being within 10km by 1905. The treated cohort is those who are 0-5 in 1906, as compared to those who are 12-17. Railway distance in the distance in 1906. Homestead is a control for the type of land parcel a family is on in 1906. Family birthplace are controls for own, father's and mother's birthplace. Livestock controls for family holdings of cattle, hogs, horses, milk cows, and sheep in 1906 as taken from the census. Agricultural conditions are for the agricultural productivity in wheat, oats, barley, flax, and reed canary grass. The link probability is a model derived probability of a link being correct from the MLP linking.

Within an occupation there is significant heterogeneity. The two digit category for Agents contain a variety of industries. There is a slight increase in the likelihood of being an agent as an adult, but the occupation of agent is broad and could span a variety of industries. Figure 6 breaks down the industries that agents are working in, and further separates agents by birthplace. The lefthand table shows agents who grew up in rural areas, while the righthand table shows agents who grew up in urban areas. Agents who grew up in rural areas are most likely to be found working at a grain elevator, while agents who grew up in urban areas are most likely to be found working in insurance. This suggests that although one room schools may have shifted occupations away from agriculture, children who grew up on a farm may still be using their agricultural knowledge in their later professions and working in agriculture adjacent services. Table 30 in the appendix finds similar effects for managers, those who grew up in rural areas are more likely to be managers of a farm.

Table 6: Agents in 1931

Industry	n
Unknown	130
Grain Elevator	55
Insurance	45
General	12
Real Estate	9
Steam Railway	9
General Farm	6
Lumber Mill	5
Retail Hardware	5
Steam Railroad	5
Other	28

Grew up Rural

Industry	n
Unknown	96
Insurance	29
Real Estate	10
Grain Elevator	7
Steam Railway	5
Mill Farm	4
Wholesale Grocery	3
Financial	2
Automobile	1
Barber Shop	1
Other	15

Grew up Urban

5.3 Farm Size

Due to the large distances in the Canadian prairies farms were required to be occupied by the owner or renter of the land and there is no separation between home and work location. The previous results listed above find that access to education increased the likelihood of leaving agriculture as an adult and moving away from home. If all land is occupied by the farmer, then this would imply that the average farm size should increase by roughly the same amount as the rate of people leaving agriculture, assuming no in migration.

I test this by estimating the effect of school openings on farm size. I utilize the set of geolocated farms in 1906, 1921, and 1931 in their entirety, allowing for new farmers to take over existing farms. Using the geolocation for each farm combined with the panel of school opening dates gives different exposures for each farm to access to school. A farm is defined as being close to a school if it had a school constructed within 5 kilometers by 1912 at the end of the school opening data $p_i = \mathbb{1}\{dist_i < 5km\}$. Farms are considered to have had a school early relative to other farms if that school was constructed before 1906 $s_j = \mathbb{1}\{date_j < 1906\}$. Finally there is a time dimension consisting of the years 1906, 1921, and 1931 (T_t).

The following specification is then estimated in a triple difference setup:

$$y_{ijt} = \beta p_i s_j T_t + p_i s_j + s_j T_t + p_i T_t + p_i + T_t + \alpha_j + \epsilon_{i,j,t} \tag{4}$$

where β is the coefficient of interest. Instead of including s_j directly, a school fixed effect α_j is included to control for any geographic characteristics.

Table 7 shows the results. The coefficient in the third row shows the interaction between having a constructed early and nearby in 1906, the second row the interaction with 1921, and the third row with 1931. It is this top coefficient, which gives the estimated effect on farm sizes in 1931 from school construction. Column 1 gives the most basic specification, while columns 2 through 5 add controls for farm size. I choose the farm size controls based on the farm size validation results from table 21 in the appendix, controlling for family characteristics which are available in all census waves and correlate with farm size. Column 5 gives the preferred specification.

I find that farm sizes increase by 5.24% around where schools are constructed in 1931. Schools are initially constructed in areas with 5.14% smaller farms (as indicated in the "Close" row), consistent with schools being built in more populated areas. The 5.25% in farm sizes around schools closely aligns with the 6% decline in farm work estimated in section 5.1. Although some immigration may have occurred to areas to offset children migrating elsewhere, it was not enough to offset the outmigration from school construction.

6 Conclusion

The one room school house in the Canadian (and American) prairies promoted mobility. This paper uses geolocated households and schools to show that these rural schools encouraged school participation, that school participation gave children new opportunities outside of agriculture, and that the estimated causal impact of school construction was to push children out of farming. Children moved further from home, earned more income, and entered higher skilled services. This is consistent with education acting as a push factor for structural change out of agriculture, but not to manufacturing as we typically expect.

What are potential mechanisms behind this migration? The existing literature on education on structural transformation has argued that education drives structural transformation by endowing people with human capital, which is more complementary with non agricultural production (Porzio, Rossi, and Santangelo 2022). Yet previous work by Goldin and Katz (2000) has found that the returns to one room schools were similar in agricultural and non-agricultural occupations. Why then switch? One possibility is that the schools changed preferences for over sectors without affecting human capital. Distinguishing the importance of the human capital formed versus giving students a view for life beyond the farm remains an important area for future study.

Table 7: School Construction and Farm Size

Dependent Variable:	Ln Farm Area				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Early × Close × Year = 1931	0.0677*	0.0467	0.0500	0.0522*	0.0524*
	(0.0383)	(0.0316)	(0.0316)	(0.0315)	(0.0314)
Early × Close × Year = 1921	-0.0062	-0.0161	-0.0134	-0.0152	-0.0159
	(0.0383)	(0.0319)	(0.0319)	(0.0317)	(0.0316)
Early × Close	-0.0174	-0.0040	-0.0087	-0.0068	-0.0063
	(0.0313)	(0.0269)	(0.0269)	(0.0268)	(0.0267)
Constant	6.358***				
	(0.0292)				
Early	-0.0099				
	(0.0323)				
Close	-0.1090***	-0.0521***	-0.0533***	-0.0516***	-0.0514**
	(0.0242)	(0.0200)	(0.0200)	(0.0200)	(0.0200)
Year = 1921	-0.1588***	-0.1835***	-0.2336***	-0.1981***	-0.1982***
	(0.0309)	(0.0254)	(0.0254)	(0.0255)	(0.0254)
Year = 1931	-0.0735**	-0.0786***	-0.1347***	-0.0821***	-0.0822***
	(0.0309)	(0.0256)	(0.0256)	(0.0258)	(0.0257)
Early × Year = 1921	-0.0166	0.0384	0.0481	0.0358	0.0347
	(0.0387)	(0.0321)	(0.0321)	(0.0322)	(0.0321)
Early × Year = 1931	-0.0557	-0.0074	0.0019	-0.0209	-0.0211
	(0.0381)	(0.0318)	(0.0318)	(0.0319)	(0.0319)
Close × Year = 1921	0.0505*	0.0463**	0.0476**	0.0503**	0.0500**
	(0.0267)	(0.0218)	(0.0217)	(0.0217)	(0.0217)
Close × Year = 1931	0.0381	0.0349	0.0345	0.0314	0.0311
	(0.0273)	(0.0221)	(0.0221)	(0.0221)	(0.0221)
Homestead			-0.2102***	-0.2117***	-0.2118***
			(0.0052)	(0.0052)	(0.0052)
RR Dist in Year				0.0381***	0.0381***
				(0.0036)	(0.0036)
Family Size					-0.0005
					(0.0006)
Fam. Adult Males					0.0044***
					(0.0016)
School District		Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	412,918	412,918	412,918	412,918	412,918
R^2	0.00667	0.13645	0.15332	0.15527	0.15577

Clustered (Enum. Sub.) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

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7 Appendix

7.1 Selected Quotes

There is significant evidence from the department of education reports that school attendance in rural areas was significantly lower that desired, and that boys in particular were leaving school at a faster rate than girls. The following quotes provide some accounts of the challenges in rural schools from the saskatchewan department of education (Saskatchewan Department of Education 1906, 1907, 1908, 1910, 1911, 1912, 1914).

"Parents who keep children out of school because of distance or danger, appear to have no hesitation in sending the boys to market" - A. Kennedy, Inspector of Schools, 1910

"The attendance in rural districts is not so regular as one would expect or could hope for. Undoubtedly, it is in part due to the scarcity of farm help and the long distances some children have to go; but I fear it is also caused by a lack of interest on the part of many parents" - H.H. Smith, Inspector of Schools, Saskatoon, December 31, 1909

"When a boy is old enough to work an outfit on a farm, his school days are over" - John S. Huff, Davidson, Saskatchewan., March 1st, 1912

7.2 Land Allocation

Dominion land policy was marked by frequent changes between the acquisition of Rupert's Land and the North-West Territories and later settlement. I rely on Lambrecht (1991) as the primary source of both narrative and legislative background. As described in section 2.1 the primary landholders after settlement were railways, homesteaders, the Hudson's Bay Company, and land reserved for the funding of schools. Despite the relative simplicity of this formula, there was significant variation and modification of land policy that is not captured by it.

To fund the construction of railways, approximately 32 million acres was given away as grants to encourage construction between 1881 and 1894. The system was initiated to subsidize the construction of the Canadian Pacific Railway (CPR), but also applied to a multitude of smaller railways as well. Like Canadian land policy in general, there was significant variation in policy over time before the pattern seen in figure 1 became firmly established.

The 1870's featured a variety of attempts at establishing land grants and highlighted conflicting goals in Canadian policy. The first grant system in 1871 allowed three full townships (approximately 18 miles) on either side of the railway to be withdrawn as a grant, superseded in 1872 by the Dominion Lands Act which allowed land to be withdrawn up to 20 miles on either side. Reserving these lands for the railway had the unintended consequence of limiting settlement, another main goal of the government. To overcome this the land grant policy was modified again in 1879 to allow belts of land at different distances to have different checkerboard patterns with homesteads and railway land. Finally in 1881 the Canadian Pacific Railway Act authorized the current system, with alternate sections within 24 miles of the railway given to the CPR for a total of 25 million acres.

Other railways constructed across the prairies had similar arrangements with the government. Individual contracts typically specified 6,400 acres of land for mile of line, the equivalent of every other section within a 20 mile band around the railway. In all of these contracts, including the CPR, was an indemnity provision which allowed the railway to not take a particular parcel of land if it was not "fairly fit for settlement". This provision meant that railways would often select lands that were far from their railway line, especially as rail lines started to cross. Although land grants were removed in 1894, the indemnity provision led to a delay in railways selecting their parcels, which was not resolve until 1908.

After the railway land grant system ended there were still significant supports for railway construction through subsidized corporate debt. The Railway Act allowed a rail company to pass through the subsidy lands of another, encouraging more railway construction. Railways began to consolidate as well, with Canadian Northern forming from absorbing smaller railways with land grants, and later merging with Grand Trunk Pacific to form Canadian National.

Railway construction was primarily devised to support settlement, which was enabled through homesteads. The homestead system was designed to compete with the United States, including advertisements at which referred to Canada as the "Last Best West" (Sharp 1947). As a result the homestead system in Canada resembles that of the United States, but with additional features that would make it more appealing to would be settlers. As with railway land there was some variance in policy over time.

At the core of the system was a 160 acre quarter section, which would occupy one quarter of a section of land. The majority of homesteads would be on even numbered sections, except for 8 and 26, with some railway sections also being sold as homesteads if the railway used the indemnity provision to not take possession of a particular parcel. Obtaining a homestead first required "entry" by filing for a homestead at a Dominion Lands office, followed by a three year period of homestead duties which required living on and cultivating that parcel. After fulfilling homestead duties, the homesteader could apply for letters patent, or "perfecting" the homestead, and become the owner of the parcel. Some homesteaders purchased their land in less than three years.

While applying for entry, homesteaders were able to apply for pre-emption, or a second parcel of land which was contiguous with the homestead. The homesteader could cultivate this land immediately, and could be purchased after fulfilling homestead duties. The combination of pre-emption and railway indemnity slowed the rate of settlement by restricting the amount of land available. As a result the right of pre-emption was removed in 1890, then reintroduced in 1908 after the railway indemnities were resolved. More than half of homestead entries would include a pre-emption.

The eligibility for a homestead was intentionally broad. In 1874 the required age was reduced from 21 to 18, and in 1876 women were excluded unless they were the head of the household. There were no nationality requirements until 1908, when it was required that a homesteader had to be or intend to be a British subject. After 1916 at the start of World War I, entry was restricted to British subjects.

There were some other mechanisms that could be used to obtain homestead land. From 1883 to 1886 it was possible to have a second homestead, and this was again possible after 1908. Widespread crop failures after WWI prompted the government to allow a second homestead if the first had failed. In 1881 there were also colonization companies, which would purchase land and receive rebates depending on the success of their sales. Approximately 3 million acres were allocated to these companies, but they failed after the completion of the initial boom of construction with the CPR in 1885.

The final method for land allocation was as a reward for military service. Grants and scrip were given for service in the militia and North-West Mounted Police starting in 1871, with repeated extensions for entry until 1900. A similar program was established for soldier and nurses who participated in the Boer War, and involved the transfer of approximately 2 million acres in Saskatchewan and 1 million acres in Alberta. This transfer was criticized for not imposing any domicile conditions unlike regular homesteads. Finally soldiers returning from WWI were able to make an entry for an additional 160 acres in addition to a regular homestead, with subsided loans to strengthen agricultural life and "make men settlers".

The Hudson's Bay Company (HBC) was granted 5% of all available land in the fertile belt in exchange for Rupert's Land and the North-West Territories as part of the deed of surrender. This land amounted to section 8 in every township, the entirety of section 26 in every fifth township, and three quarter of section 26 in four fifths of the townships [6]. The fertile belt was defined as the land bounded by the United States border to the south, the North Saskatchewan river to the north, the Rocky Mountains to the west, and the Laek Winnipeg-Lake of the Woods water system to the east. In addition the HBC was given title to any land that it had fur trading posts on and adjacent parcels not to exceed 50,000 acres. There were some negotiations to allow the government to fufil other objectives if section 8 or 26 were needed, but by 1924 a total of 6,639,059 acres had been given to the HBC.

The HBC, recognizing the value of the land that it had been granted, held onto it's portfolio of land strategically and only sold parcels when the surrounding area had been settled to maximize the value (B. Hamilton, n.d.). This strategy was achieved by first allowing settlement to occur in the surrounding land, including the development of railways. Land closer to railways would sell faster (B. Hamilton, n.d.). The HBC continued to sell land throughout the twentieth century, and by 1961 formed the Rupert's Land Trading Company to administer the remaining parcles. By 1984 the final 5,100 acres in Saskatchewan were donated to the Saskatchewan Wild Life Federation (B. Hamilton, n.d.).

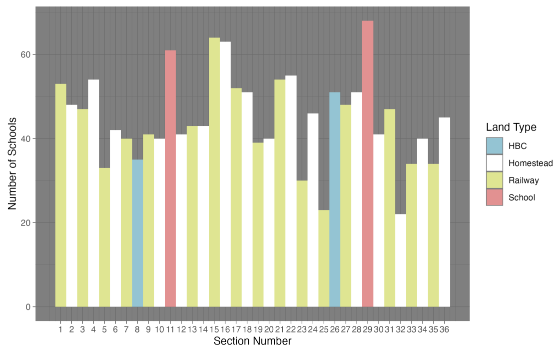
Sections 11 and 29 were explicitly reserved to fund school boards. Unlike the United States (Schaede 2021) these "school sections" were not sold or rented to fund local school boards. Instead revenue from sales and rentals was collection by the federal government and placed in the School Endowment Fund. These funds were invested in Dominion securities, with the revenues distributed to the provinces.

As with the HBC land the government held off on selling land until the surrounding land was settled to maximize the value. There was a bias towards leasing land rather than selling, to maintain a steady flow of income.

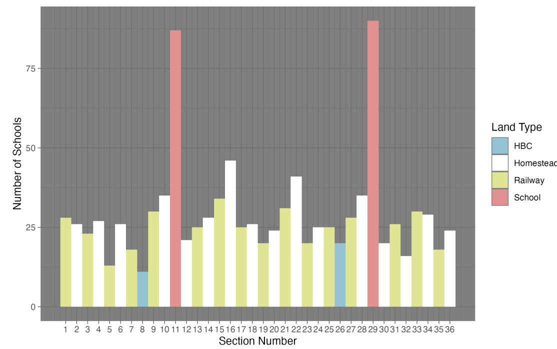
There is some evidence that schools were more likely to locate on school sections relative to other parcels. This appears largely true in Saskatchewan, less so in Alberta, and not at

6. $\frac{1}{36} + \frac{1}{36} * \frac{1}{5} + \frac{3/4}{36} * \frac{4}{5} = 1/20$

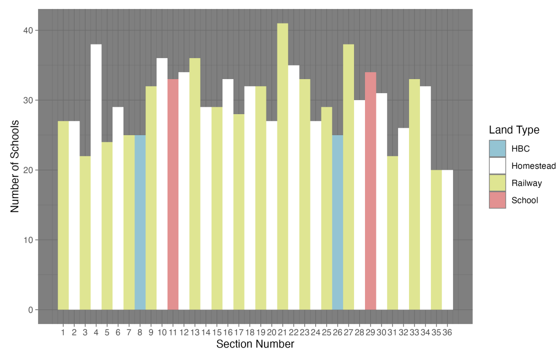
all in Manitoba. This could reflect the lower transaction costs to construct schools on land explicitly designated for schools. Figure 18 shows the distribution of schools across sections.



(a) Alberta



(b) Saskatchewan



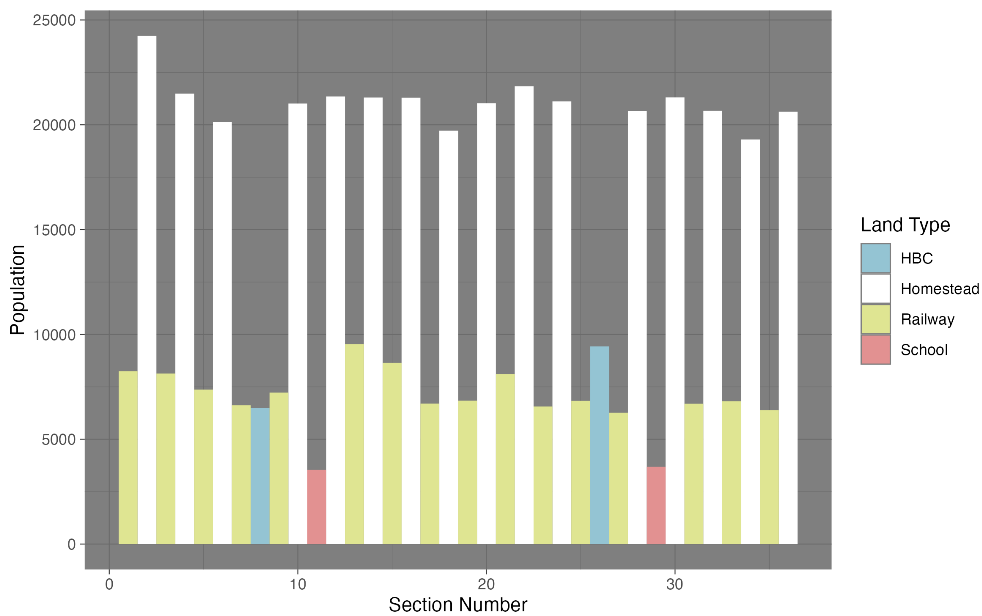
(c) Manitoba

Figure 12: Distribution of schools by section type by province.

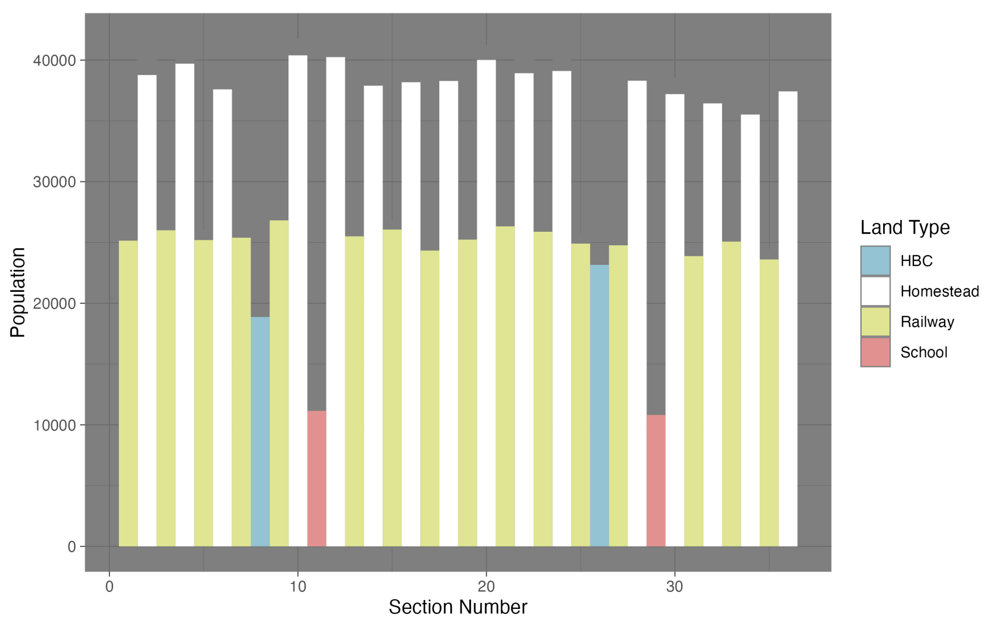
Figure 13 shows the distribution of population by section in 1906 and 1921, two of the census years where the section number is available. School and HBC sections were the least populated in both years, consistent with those sections being sold off strategically once the surrounding areas had been settled. The highest population sections are the homesteads, although this gap narrows in 1921. This is consistent with railway lands being slower to settle due to the indemnity provision in railway contracts.

7.3 Separate Schools

The Northwest Territories Act of 1875 gave the Territorial Council the right to pass ordinances regarding education, on the condition that the religious minority of either Protestants or Catholics could establish their own school and ratepayers would only be liable for the school of their religion (Moir 1934; Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). The first major ordinance, The North-West Territory School Ordinance of 1884, created a system of school districts, with every district designated as either Protestant or Catholic. The original intention was to create a "Dual" system similar to Quebec and Manitoba, with separate school systems for Protestants and Catholics (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). Protestant and Catholic schools were overseen by a Catholic and Protestant sections, overseen by the Board



(a) 1906



(b) 1921

Figure 13: Population distribution between land parcel types in 1906 and 1921. Early in the settlment process the majority of settlers lived on even numbered sections which were sold as homesteads. Over time more settlement occurred on railway, school, and Hudson's Bay Company lands, as evidenced by the figure from 1921.

of Education (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). Each section separately determined subjects, textbooks, and teachers for the schools of their own faith (Moir 1934).

The "Dual" system didn't last, and was changed to a "minority" system similar to that of Ontario in 1885 (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). The minority system allowed two schools to operate simultaneously in a given area. The first school, either Protestant or Catholic, would be designated a "public" school. The minority in an area could then vote and create a "separate" school district, either Protestant or Catholic, for people of that faith. In several instances changing population of Catholics and Protestants led to a separate school, which was supported by the majority of tax payers (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). Initially the boundaries of a separate school district did not need to overlap with the public school district, but this was changed so that both school districts had the same boundaries in 1892 (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006; Moir 1934).

Although the minority system remained in place in the Northwest Territories, the differences between the Protestant and Catholic sections, and their influence, decreased over time. In 1885 the Board of Education was reduced to five members, two Catholic, two Protestant, and the lieutenant governor (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). In 1887 the Board of Education took over the power to license teachers, meaning that Protestants and Catholics both jointly determine the teachers for each other's schools, despite differences in the materials being taught (Moir 1934). In 1891 and 1892 most of the power of the sections was removed with the lieutenant-governor-in-council taking over licensing of teachers, appointment of inspectors, the use of uniform textbooks, and uniform examination standards (Moir 1934). Finally in 1901 a commissioner of education was created to administer schools, to be advised by an Educational Council consisting of three Protestants and two Catholics.

The differences in instruction across schools were also reduced over time. Religious education was limited to the last half hour of the day after 1892, with the religion determined by the local school board (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). Following the Riel Rebellion in 1885 and a subsequent rise in anti-French sentiment, English was mandated as the language of instruction in 1901 (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006), with provisions for teaching some primary courses in French (Moir 1934).

In practice, the majority of separate schools were Catholic, although a small number of separate Protestant schools were established in Catholic majority areas. To fund schools, Protestants and Catholics each paid taxes to the school of their respective faith, and after 1886 no owner of property was able to escape taxation all together (Moir 1934). Prior to 1909 residents could determine which school board they would like to fund, but after a legal case it was determined that the assessment of taxes would be on the basis of religious faith, not personal preference (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006). Further legal opinions clarified that for the purposes of establishing a separate school, a Catholic was someone who believed that religious authority rests with the pope[7] (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006).

Details on how separate schools are handled in the data are discussed in section 7.6.1.

7. As of 2018 this definition is still used in Alberta. This confusingly leads people who are Eastern Orthodox or Ukrainian Orthodox to be considered Protestants for the purposes of establishing a separate school board (Government of Alberta 2018).

7.4 Census Records

The Canadian full count census records are available courtesy of The Canadian People's project (The Canadian Peoples, n.d.) and a partnership with Ancestry.com. The records used in this project consist of waves starting in 1901 and ending 1931, the most recent wave released[8]. I utilize both census waves that cover the entirety of Canada in 1901, 1911, 1921, and 1931, and census waves that cover the prairie provinces only in 1906, 1916, and 1926. These additional waves, taken to track the growth of the west after the creation of Alberta and Saskatchewan in 1905 (Canada 2023a), mean that the relevant areas have census waves every five years.

Although the census was being conducted frequently, different years of the census contain different information. The availability of different variables is recorded in table 8. One important advantage that the Canadian census has is that income is available every ten years starting in 1901, nearly forty years prior to the United States first asking about income in 1940.

7.5 Linking

In the first stage, when linking males, blocking is done on sex, age within a three year window, the first letter of the surname, and the recorded birthplace (aggregated to the province, United States, United Kingdom, Ireland, or continent). Following Helgertz et al. (2022), the set of potential links is restricted to those with a levenstein distance of 0.79 in the first name, and 0.84 in the surname. The list of potential links is then scored with trained model to predict the likelihood of two records being linked. In order for a link to be accepted, the probability of a link being correct must be greater than a threshold $\alpha = 0.25$, and the score for a proposed link must better that the next best link by at least $\beta = \frac{\alpha_1}{\alpha_2} = 1.1$.

In the second stage the links in the first stage are used to infer family links across census waves. A second round of linking is then completed after blocking at the family level. A second model is used to score links within the family, with the same thresholds for α and β applied. Linking within family also allows blocking variables to be ignored, allowing for matches where some characteristics may have changed dramatically either due to enumerator error or deliberate choice on the part of the person being recorded. This is especially important to correct for transcription errors.

7.5.1 Linking Variables

In order to score potential matches I use the training data from Helgertz et al. (2022) which links US census records. The variables used in stage 1 of linking between individuals can be found in table 9. The names of variables created in the Canadian data are identical to those in the training data for easy reproducibility.

To compute the distances between census records I utilize the link between the census records from The Canadian Peoples, n.d. and the census subdivision (CSD) files computed by HGIS Lab, n.d. I take the centroid of each CSD for the purpose of computing the distance, and compute pairwise distances between all CSDs as a lookup table. CSD polygons are only

8. The Canadian government operates on a 92 year lag for releasing census records (Canada 2023b)

Table 8: Variables available in the Canadian census by census wave. Rural locations include the Section, Township, Range, and Meridian allowing for precise geolocation of households. 1911 excludes this information so location to the nearest township is the best possible. Some years include the exact address for urban households, although 1916 only includes the street. Income is consistently available in full census years, but missing in prairie province census years.

Year	**Name**	**Months in School**	**Location (Rural)**	**Location (Urban)**	**Income**	**Other**
1901	Yes	Yes	Not Digitized	Not Digitized	Yes	Locations contained in a separate schedule, which has not been digitized.
1906	Yes	No	Yes	No	No	Contains information on livestock holdings by each individual.
1911	Yes	Yes	No	No	Yes	Contains information on insurance holdings by individual.
1916	Yes	No	Township	Street	No	Rural addresses at the township level only. Contains information on insurance holdings by individual.
1921	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Contains information on house materials.
1926	Yes	Not Digitized	Not Digitized	Not Digitized	No	
1931	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Contains estimated value of home.

Table 9: Linking variables in Stage 1. Code refers to the name of the variable in both the Canadian data and Helgertz et al. (2022). Type gives the data type of the variable. Description offers a brief description of the variable and how it is created.

Variable	**Code**	**Type**	**Description**
Last Name JW	namelast_jw	0-1	Jaro-Winkler string distance between last names.
First Name JW	namefrst_jw	0-1	Jaro-Winkler string distance between first names.
Second Generation	sgen	Binary	Is the individual a second generation immigrant?
County Distance	distance	Continuous (m)	Distance between counties in each census wave, in meters.
Distance Squared	distance2	Continuous (m^2)	County Distance squared.
Birth Year	byrdif	Continuous	Difference between recorded birth years.
Middle Initial	mi	0, 1, or 2	0 if middle initial is empty, 1 if middle initial matches any possible middle initial, 2 if there is no possible match.
First Soundex	fsoundex	Boolean	1 if soundex matches, 0 if otherwise.
Last Soundex	lsoundex	Boolean	1 if soundex matches, 0 if otherwise.
Multiple Exact Matches	exact_mult	Boolean	1 if there are multiple exact matches with identical first and last name, 0 if otherwise
Immigration Year	immyear_caution	0, 1, 2	0 if there is no difference in immigration year or <= 5 years, 1 if the difference is <= 10 years, 2 if the difference is > 10 years. 0 if either record is missing the immigration year
Hits	hits	Integer	The number of potential matches for a given individual, looking from the first dataset
Hits Squared	hits2	Integer	Hits squared.

available in complete census years (e.g. 1901, 1911, 1921, etc.), and not for years where a census of the prairie provinces was taken (e.g. 1906, 1916, 1926, etc.). For years where I do not observe the CSD, I create a synthetic CSD based on the exact locations I can observe combined with the enumeration subdistricts or enumeration districts. For details on geolocation, see section 7.7 of the appendix.

The variables used in stage 2 of linking can be found in table 10. Note that the number of variables and type is lower than in stage 1. This reflects the fact that the stage 2 matching occurs within households based on the stage 1 link, thus requiring fewer variables to reach a similar level of precision. Unlike stage 1 no blocking is required, instead variables are included for sex, age, name initials, and birthplace codes that were previously used for blocking. This allows second stage matches between entries that might have differences across these variables. For example and individual whose sex was misrecorded in one year would not be matched in stage 1 due to the blocking on sex, but could be matched in stage 2 if another family member was matched and enough other characteristics are similar between the two census waves.

Table 10: Linking variables in Stage 2. Code refers to the name of the variable in both the Canadian data and Helgertz et al. (2022). Type gives the data type of the variable. Description offers a brief description of the variable and how it is created.

Variable	**Code**	**Type**	**Description**
Last Name JW	namelast_jw	0-1	Jaro-Winkler string distance between last names.
First Name JW	namefrst_jw	0-1	Jaro-Winkler string distance between first names.
Sex	sexmatch	Boolean	Indicates if two records have matching sex.
Relation Type	idtype	1, 2, or 3	1 if both entries are biologically related family, 2 if both entries are non biologically related famiy, 3 otherwise.
Birthplace	bplmatch	Boolean	1 if birthplace code matches, 0 if otherwise.
Birth Year	byrdifcat	Continuous	Difference between recorded birth years. No restriction on maximum possible difference like in stage 1.
First Initial Match	f1_match	1 or 2	1 if the first initial of the first first name matches any of the potential first initials, 2 otherwise.
Middle Initial Match	f2_match	0, 1, or 2	0 if middle initial is empty, 1 if middle initial matches any possible middle initial, 2 if there is no possible match. Analogous to middle initial match in stage 1.

For details on the Hlink package used the implement the linking, please see the Github page for Hlink (Wellington, Harper, and Thompson 2024).

7.5.2 Linking Comparison

The linking method used in this paper from Helgertz et al. (2022) (MLP), is a relative newcomer to the linking literature. The more established method of Abramitzky et al. (2021) (ABE) offers greater transparency in the linking process, at the cost of excluding some potentially useful information that might allow for larger match rates and more precise matches.

To compare the performance of these two methods I focus on matches between 1906 and 1911 and compute matches using both the ABE and MLP methods. Table 11 shows the number of matches using both the MLP and ABE methods for the target sample of children. Both methods have a significant overlap in the matched population of 41359, but MLP recognizes a much larger set off additional links of 64664, relative to ABE at 14602. This is consistent with MLP using more information to disambiguate links, leading to a higher match rate.

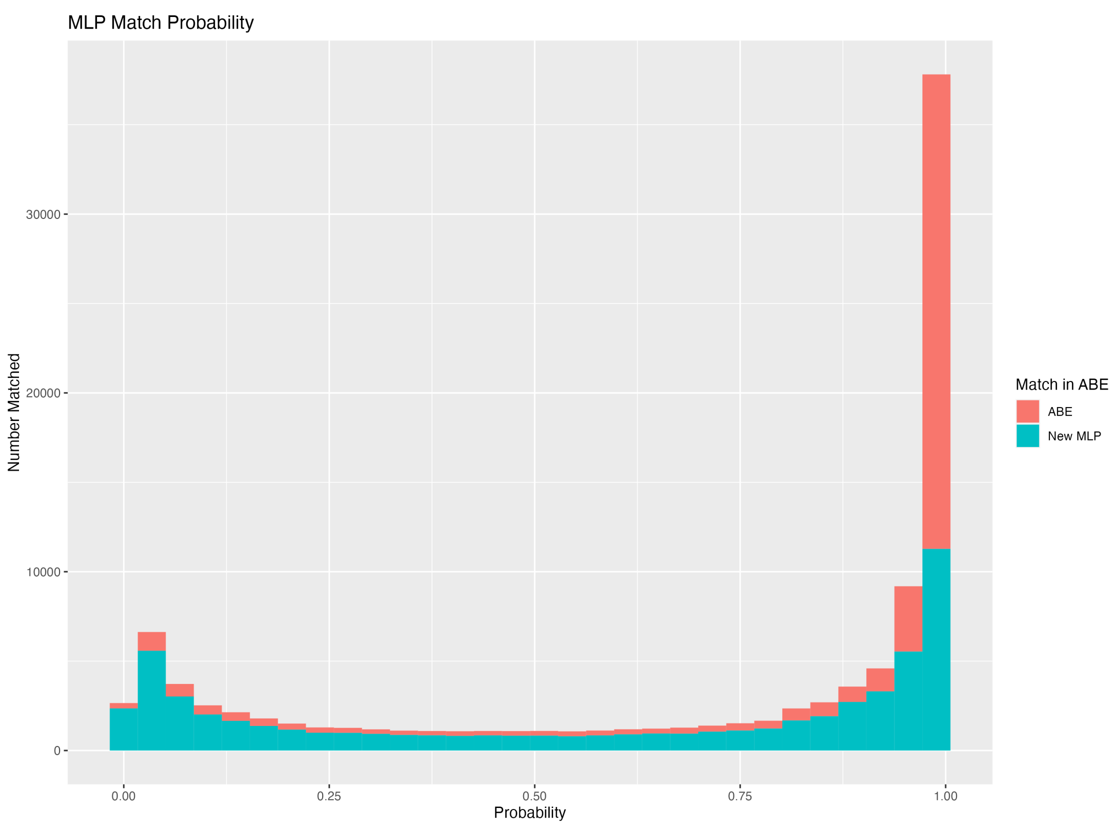
Table 11: Links by ABE vs MLP between the 1906 and 1911 Canadian Census. Links are generated for children who are between the ages of 0 and 17 in 1906 and who live in Alberta, Saskatchewan, or Manitoba. MLP links are generated using the procedure document in section 7.5.1. ABE links are generated by first blocking on sex, place of birth, and fathers place of birth. No NYSIIS name cleaning is applied, and the loosest requirements for an exact match are used, requiring uniqueness only on the exact age to be considered a match.

Method	In MLP	Not in MLP	Total
In ABE	32867	23094	55961
Not in ABE	47303	197091	244394
Total	80170	220185	300355

To understand where additional matches are coming from, I plot the likelihood scores for each match in figure 14, and decompose the matches into whether they are an ABE match or are a new MLP match. These likelihoods can only be computed for matches that are completed by MLP, thus the matches are the equivalent of those in column 1 of table 11. I find that the ABE matches have a large mass near 1, with a tail that extends all the way to zero. This suggests that ABE is picking up the highest quality matches, but that by failing to take into account additional information some very low quality links are created. MLP in contrast picks up the high quality matches that ABE does, but also many others whose likelihood is lower. Importantly by creating an explicit score, the researcher is able to select only those matches which have a high probability of being a correct match. Note that this method does not score any ABE matches which are not captured at all by MLP, the "In ABE" and "Not in MLP" group in table 11. If these matches were to be included, there would be a heavier tail of low probability matches attributed to ABE. The results suggest that MLP is able to tell apart matches that may be present, but are not as obvious.

The ability to distinguish between two otherwise identical records in MLP comes at a cost of potentially introducing bias in the matching procedure. One of the most likely sources

Figure 14: MLP Match Probability vs ABE Links. This figure includes all links that are captured by MLP. Links that are not captured by MLP do not have a score, and cannot be included.



of bias is the inclusion of distance as a linking variable. If the locations of the individual between two census waves are closer, then a higher probability of a link being true will be predicted. The consequence of this is that any predicted mobility estimates will be biased towards zero, as the match probability decreases with distance. To get a sense of the magnitude of this problem, we can compare the density distribution between matches made by ABE versus those made by MLP in figure 14. I find that MLP dramatically increases the number of matches for individuals in close proximity, but that there are gains in the count of matches across the entire distribution of distances. The distribution of counts can be seen in figure 15a. When examining the density in figure 15b I find that the densities are remarkably similar, although there is slightly more mass at lower distances. Taken together this suggests that although including distance as a linking variable may introduce some bias, it is unlikely to dramatically change any results.

7.5.3 Linking Charateristics

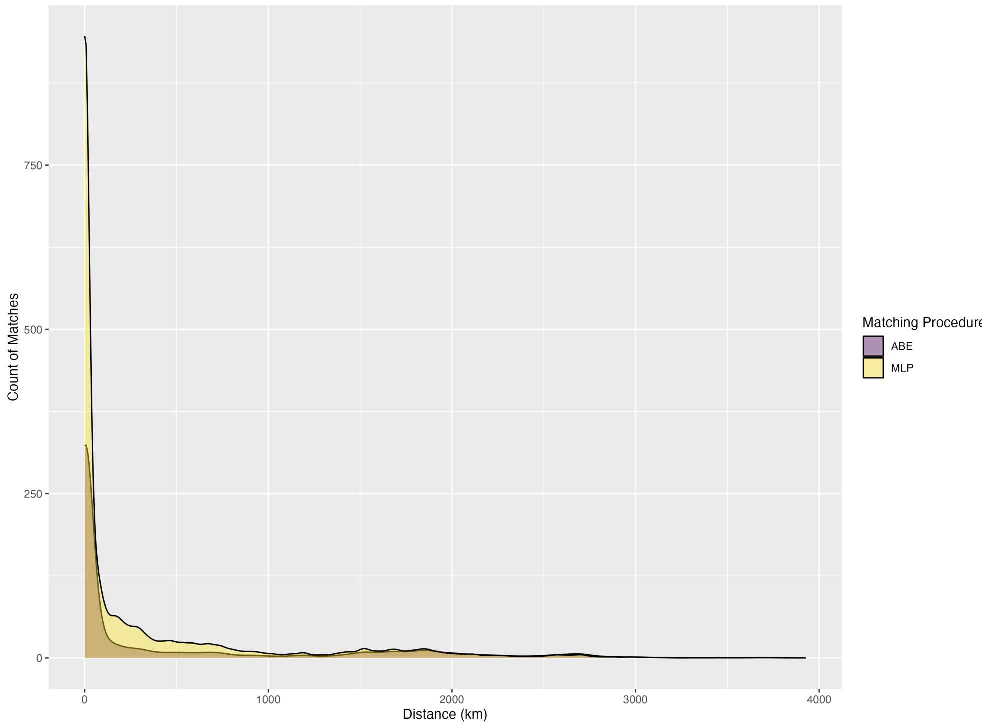
All linking proceedures are biased and are likely to be unrepresentative of the population that we want to link (Helgertz et al. 2022). It is therefore important to understand which populations are likely to be linked and if this may bias any of the results. To do this, I estimate the likelihood of being linked conditional on being in the first of a pair of census waves. This choice is made so that I can utilize the 1906 sample as the first wave, which only include the prairie provinces, at the cost of being an understatement of the likelihood of being linked as some people will have emmigrated or died and will be impossible to link.

To understand why I take the the likelihood of being matched conditional on appearing in the first census wave, consider the opposite. To evaluate the effect of the match between 1906 and 1911, we would take the later wave, and remove anyone born after 1906 and who immigrated after 1906. The fraction of people remaining who are linked would be the estimated linkage rate. The 1911 census contains the entirety of Canada, so the total match rate would be too low, as only those in 1906 who were in Alberta, Saskatchewan, and Manitoba would be linked, relative to the entire population of Canada in 1911. This would not be an accurate measure of the likelihood of being linked. An alternate approach would be to restrict the sample to those living in Alberta, Saskatchewan, and Manitoba in 1911 to get the denominator correct, but this would remove the possibility of people moving out of the prairies. Instead I take the earlier year, being concious that some individual will not be matched.

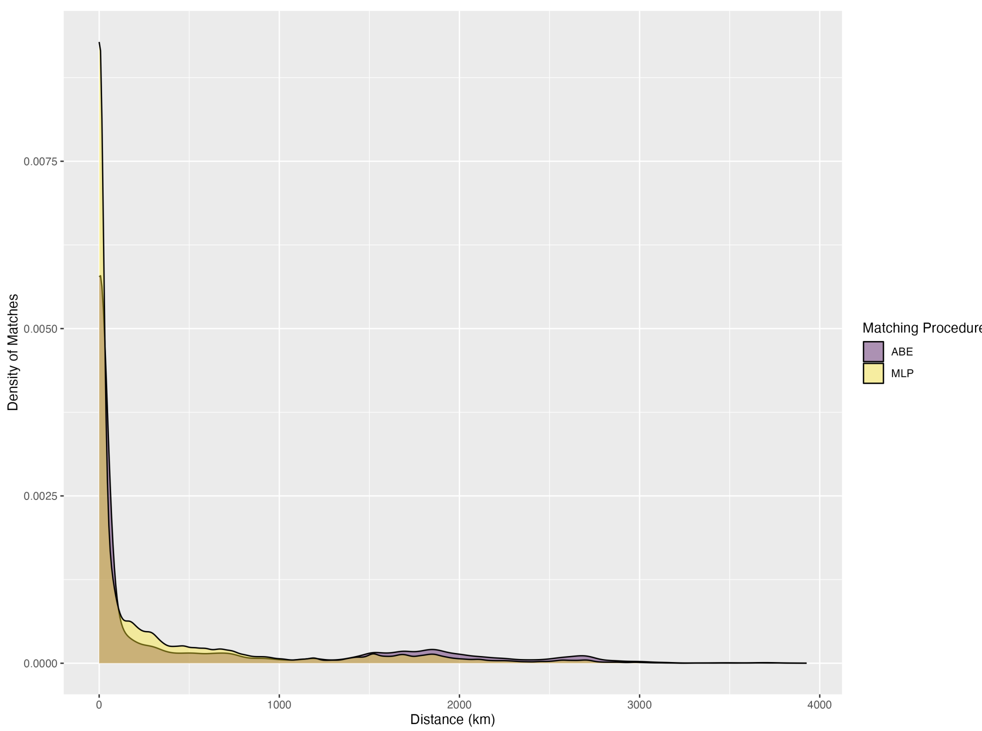
For each pair of census waves I regress the likelihood of being matched of a set of characteristics of the individual including age, birthplace, relation to the head of household, enumeration subdistrict, religion, whether the household lives on a homestead, family holdings of cows and horses, and agricultural productivity of wheat. All effect of estimated jointly. Tables 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, and 17 give the results.

7.6 Schools

After collecting the original school data from each of the three sources, several cleaning steps are required to obtain the opening date and location of each school.



(a) Count of matches.



(b) Density of matches.

Figure 15: Distribution of distance between matches in 1906-1911, for children in Alberta, Saskatchewan, and Manitoba who are between the ages of 0 and 17.

Table 12: Linking rates by Age

Dependent Variable:			Matched		
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	1906-1911	1906-1921	1906-1931	1911-1921	1911-1931
Age = 1	0.0730***	0.0786***	0.0673***	0.0686***	0.0367***
Age = 2	0.0074*	0.0155***	0.0583***	-0.0178***	0.0132***
Age = 3	-0.0355***	0.0100***	0.0521***	-0.0302***	0.0088***
Age = 4	-0.0083**	0.0209***	0.0443***	0.0052***	0.0201***
Age = 6	-0.0268***	-0.0569***	-0.0872***	-0.0325***	-0.0582***
Age = 7	-0.0458***	-0.1299***	-0.1473***	-0.0806***	-0.1143***
Age = 8	-0.0642***	-0.1663***	-0.1502***	-0.1197***	-0.1272***
Age = 9	-0.1267***	-0.1751***	-0.1359***	-0.1434***	-0.1211***
Age = 10	-0.1999***	-0.1869***	-0.1474***	-0.1499***	-0.1134***
Age = 11				-0.1073***	-0.0706***
Age = 12				-0.1558***	-0.1033***
Sex	0.1307***	0.1465***	0.1467***	0.1197***	0.1084***
Family Size	0.0041***	0.0010***	0.0001	-5.8×10^{-5}	$-7.95 \times 10^{-5***}$
Birthplace	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Relation	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Enum. Subdist.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Homestead	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Milk Cows	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Horses	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Wheat Prod.	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Religion				Yes	Yes
Observations	430,101	430,101	430,101	1,191,247	1,191,247
R^2	0.08367	0.08690	0.10244	0.05913	0.06569

Clustered (Enum. Subdist.) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Linking rates by age for different decades of life. The reference group is those in the 5th age group, those between the ages of 40-49. Each column gives the estimated effect for different pairs of matched years. Columns (1), (2) and (3) focus on the rural population who are able to be geolocated and are the population of interest. Columns (4) and (5) are census waves which include all of Canada, but are restricted to people in Alberta, Manitoba, and Saskatchewan.

Table 13: Linking rates by Birthplace

Dependent Variable:	Matched				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	1906-1911	1906-1921	1906-1931	1911-1921	1911-1931
Sex	0.1307***	0.1465***	0.1467***	0.1197***	0.1084***
Family Size	0.0041***	0.0010***	0.0001	-5.8×10^{-5}	-7.95×10^{-5}***
Birthplace = UnitedStates	-0.0347***	-0.0533***	-0.0462***	-0.0260***	-0.0283***
Birthplace = Canada+BC	-0.0491***	-0.0425***	-0.0391***	-0.0131***	-0.0101***
Birthplace = MB	-0.0378***	-0.0389***	-0.0417***	0.0113***	0.0062***
Birthplace = Maritimes	-0.0322***	-0.0213***	-0.0155**	-0.0111***	-0.0132***
Birthplace = QC	-0.0563***	-0.0268***	-0.0199***	0.0067	0.0032
Birthplace = Caribbean	-0.1479***	-0.0886***	-0.1132***	-0.0441**	-0.0571***
Birthplace = Nordic	-0.0760***	-0.0547***	-0.0334***	-0.0327***	-0.0133***
Birthplace = UnitedKingdom	0.0319***	0.0322***	0.0358***	0.0003	0.0090***
Birthplace = Ireland	-0.0157*	-0.0178**	-0.0030	-0.0009	0.0065*
Birthplace = RestofEurope	-0.1094***	-0.0683***	-0.0469***	-0.0306***	-0.0115***
Birthplace = ROW	-0.0722***	-0.1175***	-0.0977***	-0.0556***	-0.0498***
Age	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Relation	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Enum. Subdist.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Homestead	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Milk Cows	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Horses	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Wheat Prod.	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Religion				Yes	Yes
Observations	430,101	430,101	430,101	1,191,247	1,191,247
R^2	0.08367	0.08690	0.10244	0.05913	0.06569

Clustered (Enum. Subdist.) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Linking rates for different birthplaces. The reference group is those born in Ontario. Each column gives the estimated effect for different pairs of matched years. Columns (1), (2) and (3) focus on the rural population who are able to be geolocated and are the population of interest. Columns (4) and (5) are census waves which include all of Canada, but are restricted to people in Alberta, Manitoba, and Saskatchewan.

Table 14: Linking rates by Land Type

Dependent Variable:	Matched		
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)
	1906-1911	1906-1921	1906-1931
Sex	0.1313***	0.1467***	0.1466***
Family Size	0.0041***	0.0011***	9.13×10^{-5}
Homestead = HBC	0.0059	-0.0019	-0.0015
Homestead = Railway	0.0004	0.0018	0.0012
Homestead = School	0.0079	-0.0006	0.0009
Age	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birthplace	Yes	Yes	Yes
Relation	Yes	Yes	Yes
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes
Milk Cows	Yes	Yes	Yes
Horses	Yes	Yes	Yes
Wheat Prod.	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	430,101	430,101	430,101
R^2	0.05674	0.06955	0.08882

Clustered (Enum. Subdist.) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Linking rates for different land types. The reference group is those living on a homestead section. Each column gives the estimated effect for different pairs of matched years. Columns (1), (2) and (3) focus on the rural population who are able to be geolocated and are the population of interest. Columns (4) and (5) are census waves which include all of Canada, but are restricted to people in Alberta, Manitoba, and Saskatchewan.

Table 15: Linking rates by Livestock Holdings

Dependent Variable:	Matched		
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)
	1906-1911	1906-1921	1906-1931
Sex	0.1313***	0.1467***	0.1466***
Family Size	0.0041***	0.0011***	9.13×10^{-5}
Milk Cows = 1-4	0.0266***	0.0266***	0.0199***
Milk Cows = 5-9	0.0537***	0.0475***	0.0372***
Milk Cows = 10-49	0.0618***	0.0495***	0.0403***
Milk Cows = 50+	0.0173	0.0080	-0.0086
Horses = 1-4	0.0311***	0.0280***	0.0205***
Horses = 5-9	0.0547***	0.0499***	0.0385***
Horses = 10-49	0.0634***	0.0559***	0.0436***
Horses = 50+	0.0406**	0.0231*	0.0205**
Age	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birthplace	Yes	Yes	Yes
Relation	Yes	Yes	Yes
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes
Homestead	Yes	Yes	Yes
Wheat Prod.	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	430,101	430,101	430,101
R^2	0.05674	0.06955	0.08882

Clustered (Enum. Subdist.) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Linking rates by livestock holdings. The reference group is those holding no cows or horses. Each column gives the estimated effect for different pairs of matched years. Columns (1), (2) and (3) focus on the rural population who are able to be geolocated and are the population of interest. Columns (4) and (5) are census waves which include all of Canada, but are restricted to people in Alberta, Manitoba, and Saskatchewan.

Table 16: Linking rates by Relation to Head

Dependent Variable:	Matched				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	1906-1911	1906-1921	1906-1931	1911-1921	1911-1931
Family Size	0.0043***	0.0013***	0.0004	-4.14×10^{-5}	-6.45×10^{-5}***
Relation = Boarder	-0.1487***	-0.1326***	-0.1166***	-0.1034***	-0.0951***
Relation = Daughter	-0.1340***	-0.2163***	-0.2192***	-0.1301***	-0.1627***
Relation = Lodger	-0.1398***	-0.1533***	-0.1187***	-0.1049***	-0.0944***
Relation = Other	-0.1284***	-0.1156***	-0.0941***	-0.0972***	-0.0842***
Relation = Sister	-0.1942***	-0.2063***	-0.1794***	-0.1756***	-0.1637***
Relation = Son	0.0110***	0.0118***	0.0425***	0.0319***	0.0435***
Relation = Wife	-0.0379***	-0.0605***	-0.0819***	-0.0285***	-0.0458***
Age	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birthplace	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Enum. Subdist.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Homestead	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Milk Cows	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Horses	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Wheat Prod.	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Religion				Yes	Yes
Observations	430,101	430,101	430,101	1,191,247	1,191,247
R^2	0.08044	0.08238	0.09728	0.05538	0.06190

Clustered (Enum. Subdist.) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Linking rates by relation to the head of household. The reference group is the head of household. Each column gives the estimated effect for different pairs of matched years. Columns (1), (2) and (3) focus on the rural population who are able to be geolocated and are the population of interest. Columns (4) and (5) are census waves which include all of Canada, but are restricted to people in Alberta, Manitoba, and Saskatchewan.

Table 17: Linking rates by Religion

Dependent Variable:	Matched	
Model:	(1)	(2)
	1911-1921	1911-1931
Sex	0.1197***	0.1084***
Family Size	-5.8×10^{-5}	-7.95×10^{-5}***
Religion = Orthodox	-0.0393***	-0.0289***
Religion = Anglican	0.0653***	0.0438***
Religion = Presbyterian	0.0681***	0.0441***
Religion = Methodist	0.0670***	0.0425***
Religion = Unitarian	0.0625***	0.0405***
Religion = Lutheran	0.0402***	0.0292***
Religion = Baptist	0.0630***	0.0425***
Religion = Mennonite	0.0105	0.0008
Religion = Pentecostal	0.0389	0.0661
Religion = Evangelical	0.0583***	0.0583***
Religion = Fundamentalist	0.0321	0.0247
Religion = Adventist	0.0461***	0.0233***
Religion = Mormon	0.0671***	0.0310***
Religion = Holiness	0.0512***	0.0319***
Religion = Spiritualist	0.0476**	0.0152
Religion = Christian	0.0283***	0.0144***
Religion = Muslim	-0.0350	-0.0278
Religion = Jewish	0.0203***	-0.0094*
Religion = Dharmic	0.0365*	0.0319
Religion = Polytheist	-0.0700***	-0.0650***
Religion = Bahai'i	-0.1391***	0.9297***
Religion = Ethical	0.0169	0.0188
Religion = Other	-0.0984***	-0.0716***
Age	Yes	Yes
Birthplace	Yes	Yes
Relation	Yes	Yes
Enum. Subdist.	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,191,247	1,191,247
R^2	0.05913	0.06569

Clustered (Enum. Subdist.) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Linking rates by religion. The reference group is Catholics. Each column gives the estimated effect for different pairs of matched years. Columns (1), (2) and (3) focus on the rural population who are able to be geolocated and are the population of interest. Columns (4) and (5) are census waves which include all of Canada, but are restricted to people in Alberta, Manitoba, and Saskatchewan.

For the Saskatchewan data there can be multiple locations reported for each school district number. This can reflect different original sources for a school's location, or can reflect if a school district spans a geographic area with the exact location of the school being unknown. Table 18 shows an example of the data. To assign unique identifiers I use the fastLink R package (Enamorado, Fifield, and Imai 2023) to deduplicate records and assign unique identifiers.

Table 18: An example of assigning unique identifiers in the Saskatchewan data. I use the fastLink package (Enamorado, Fifield, and Imai 2023) to deduplicate records, taking into account the school name, the school district number, and the township, range, and meridian. To resolve duplicates I first take the most precise locations with section numbers (or in some cases quarter section numbers), then the less precise locations with township range and meridian locations only.

Unique ID	**School Name**	**School District Number**	**Section**	**Township**	**Range**	**Meridian**
186	Alexander	1029	NA	20	29	W3
186	Alexander Plain	1029	1	20	29	W3
200	Alexandra	1908	NA	27	19	W2
200	Alexandra	1908	35	27	20	W2
200	Alexandria	1908	NA	27	19	W2
200	Alexandria	1908	NA	27	20	W2
200	Alexandria	1908	NA	28	19	W2
200	Alexandria	1908	NA	28	20	W2
200	Alexandria	1908	NA	27	19	W2

To remove duplicates I take the most precise location as the location of the school. In the case where two schools have the same level of precision (i.e. both have locations at the section level), I keep both and assign them separate identifiers. This ensures that I am likely to be over counting schools rather than under counting. I keep a single entry for any schools that don't have a location, to keep the total number of schools as accurate as possible.

Many entries in the Saskatchewan data are missing the school opening dates. In cases where the opening date is missing I infer it from the school district number. Within the Northwest Territories (later split to form Alberta and Saskatchewan in 1905) school districts were numbered sequentially. As a result if the school district numbers are known for each school, and school opening dates are known for Alberta, school opening dates can be inferred for Saskatchewan. Table 19 shows an example of how this process works in practice. When a school could have two possible opening dates, I take the earlier of the two.

After the formation of Alberta and Saskatchewan in 1905 school districts in Alberta continued to be numbered following the same order, while Saskatchewan continued with the same numbering scheme until 1911, when the government went back and filled in numbers occupied by Alberta schools (Baergen 2005; Saskatchewan Department of Education 1906, 1907, 1908, 1910, 1911, 1912, 1914). I utilize reports from the Saskatchewan department of education to get the year of school opening until the end of 1912.

I utilize the school district numbers to infer the year of opening for any missing year.

For Saskatchewan, no information is available on the date of school opening, but Alberta and Saskatchewan shared the same school numbering system until 1905 when the provinces were created (Baergen 2005). Using the known dates for Alberta, I then create a joint list of school districts, and interpolate between the known Alberta dates to determine an estimate of the opening date for each Saskatchewan school.

Table 19: Inference procedure for schools with missing establishment years. If an entry for Saskatchewan has a corresponding entry in Alberta, then it remains NA, as the school number was originally allocated to a school in Alberta when both provinces were part of the Northwest Territories. If there is no corresponding Alberta school then the date of opening can be inferred from the earlier of the two dates that surround it. Instead I turn to the annual reports of the Saskatchewan Department of Education for the overlapped values, giving a year of 1911 for Clunie.

Province	**School District Name**	**School District Number**	**Year (Data)**	**Year (Inferred)**	**Year (Archive)**
Alberta	Anderson	434	1896	1896	1896
Saskatchewan	Clunie	434	NA	NA	1911
Saskatchewan	New Finland	435	NA	1896	1896
Saskatchewan	Glenmorris	436	NA	1896	1896
Alberta	Bon Accord	438	1897	1897	1897

One possible concern with this approach is that some schools could be missing in the records for Alberta or Saskatchewan. After Alberta and Saskatchewan were formed Alberta continued with the same numbering scheme (Baergen 2005), while Saskatchewan went back and filled in new school districts with the numbers previously allocated to schools now in Alberta (Saskatchewan Department of Education 1906, 1907, 1908, 1910, 1911, 1912, 1914). As a result any schools missing from the Alberta records and present in the Saskatchewan records before the numbers previously used in Alberta were filled up would be falsely attributed to have been constructed earlier than they actually were. To resolve this I manually record which school districts were opened from the Saskatchewan Department of Education annual reports from 1906 through 1912, which record which school district numbers were reassigned (Saskatchewan Department of Education 1906, 1907, 1908, 1910, 1911, 1912, 1914).

For Manitoba I scrape Manitoba Historical Society 2019. Each school has a single page describing the location of the school and some brief history. To get the opening dates of each school I utilize the ChatGPT API to read the body of each page and return the year of construction of the school. The total school openings in each year from 1870 to 1911 can be seen in figure 16.

There are two caveats for utilizing the school data. The first is that I do not observe closing dates for any schools, and therefore assume that any school that opens remains open until 1911. This is a reasonable assumption as settlement ensured that there would always be demand for schools. The second caveat is that I do not observe if schools moved locations, and in some cases will have a second location in the dataset with way to tell when a move occurred. In these cases I take both locations as school locations, with separate school

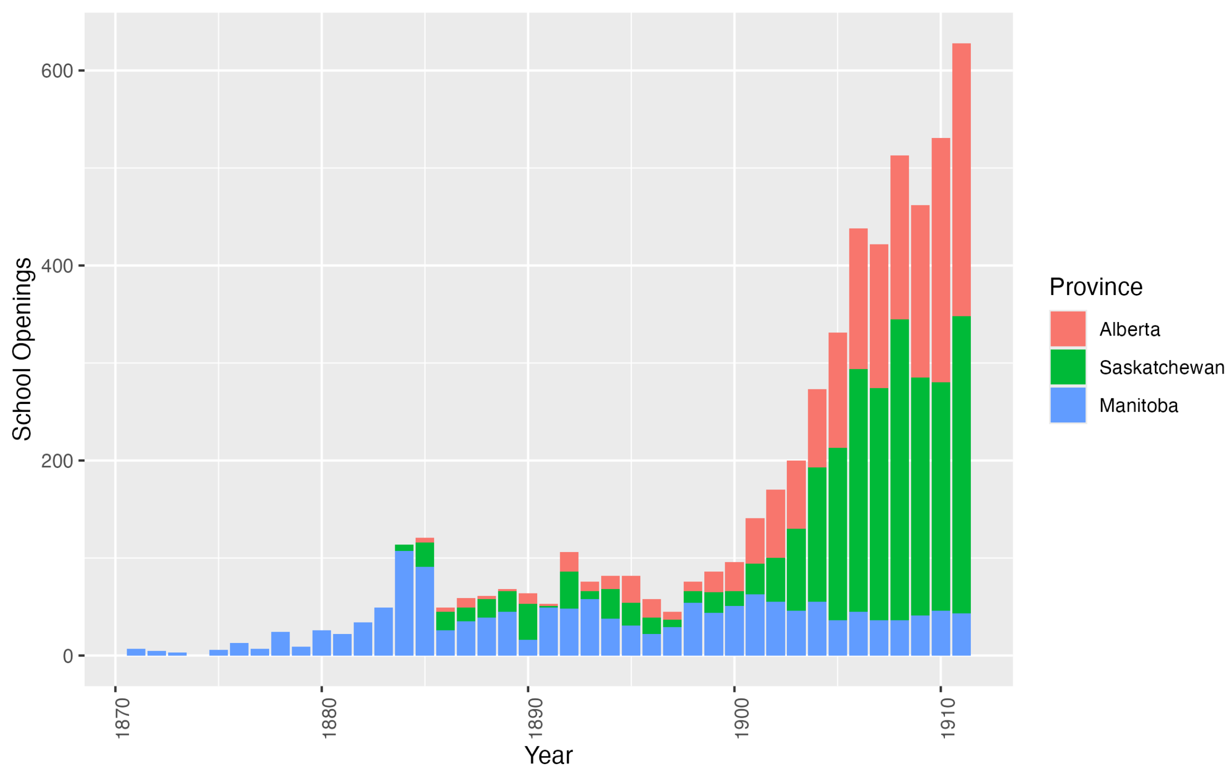


Figure 16: School openings for Alberta, Saskatchewan, and Manitoba from 1870 to 1911. Prior to 1870 only a handful of school existed in Manitoba. The last year that I have data of school openings for is 1912.

identifiers.

Table 20 shows the totals split by province of the number of schools in the database and compares this to the number of schools listed in each provinces department of education reports. I find very comparable numbers for Alberta with 1784 schools listed as being organized in 1911, versus 1750 in the data.

Table 20: Summary statistics by province for the number of schools in 1911. The first row lists the number of schools reports in the 1911 report from the department of education for Alberta (Government of Alberta 1912), Saskatchewan (Saskatchewan Department of Education 1906, 1907, 1908, 1910, 1911, 1912, 1914), and Manitoba (Government of Manitoba 1911, 1912). This figure includes both public and separate schools in Alberta and Saskatchewan while the data contain only public schools, so is a slight overestimate. The second row, "Observed" lists the number of schools I find in the data in 1911, which requires that they have an opening date before 1911. Any schools with an unknown opening date are dropped. "Geolocated" reports the number of schools, of those which are observed, which I am able to geolocate. "Geolocated (Section)" reports the number of schools where the geolocation is at the section level (1 mile square) or finer. Details on the geolocation proceedure can be found in section 7.7 of the appendix.

Type	**Total**	**Alberta**	**Saskatchewan**	**Manitoba**
Actual	5955	1784	2573	1598
Observed	5618	1750	2370	1498
Geolocated	5472	1750	2227	1495
Geolocated (Section)	4141	1619	1027	1495

7.6.1 Separate Schools

As discussed in section 7.3, the question of separate schools for Catholics and Protestants was an important feature of the late nineteenth and early twentieth century prairies. In the data I therefore need to be careful how different school boards are handled.

In Manitoba separate schools were eliminated in 1890 (Noonan, Hallman, and Scharf 2006), and the data reflect the entire set of possible schools.

In Alberta the data only contain public schools, either Protestant or Catholic, and do not contain any information on separate schools established by the minority faith. Checking the reports from the Department of Education I find that of the 1,784 schools in existence at the end of 1911, only 14 were separate schools and 5 were private schools (Government of Alberta 1912). In addition 9 of these schools were located in cities or towns, and are likely to be located near other schools as they are separate school districts. It is therefore unlikely that they are affecting my distance calculations.

In Saskatchewan there are 13 of 2,516 total school districts which were separate in 1911 (Saskatchewan Department of Education 1906, 1907, 1908, 1910, 1911, 1912, 1914). Although I can observe separate schools in the data, the numbering system for separate schools is separate for that of public schools, making it impossible to infer the opening dates from school numbers alone. Although the numbering system is shared with Alberta prior to 1905, I also don't know the school numbers for separate schools in Alberta as described the paragraph above. In addition some of the numbers of separate schools were back filled as with public schools in section 7.6, so that even a small number of opening dates is insufficient to determine the others. As a result archival research is therefore required to determine the opening date for these schools. I therefore drop all separate schools from the Saskatchewan data to be consistent with Alberta.

7.7 Geolocation

After merging shapefiles for parcels in Alberta (Government of Alberta 2020), Saskatchewan (Information Services Corporation (ISC) 2020), and Manitoba (Manitoba Government 2020), I drop parcels which do not conform to the Section-Township-Range-Meridian system. This consists primarily of river lots located in Manitoba, near Winnipeg, with 13,258 dropped out of a total of 196,864 in Manitoba. For each parcel I take the centroid as the location of the parcel. I create three different levels of aggregation at the quarter section, section, and township level.

7.7.1 Geolocating Households

To geolocate households I first split households into rural and urban households. Rural households are located via the section, township, range, and meridian, while urban households are located using CSD polygons from HGIS Lab (n.d.). In most cases the rural geolocation is more precise than the urban geolocation, as each section is only a single mile square.

To locate rural households in 1906 and 1921 I first match each household using the section, township, range and meridian to the known coordinates for that section. This gives an initial set of geolocations for each household in rural areas.

One unique feature of census records is that a single enumerator would have to travel between households in order enumerate each household. In addition the instructions to enumerators consistently advise across census years to start at one end of a district, then to move systematically to the other end[9]. As a result the path of an enumerator is informative if the geolocation of a household is correct, and significant deviations from a regular path are likely to be errors in geolocation.

To utilize this feature I first take the raw locations in 1906, and group them by enumeration subdistrict. Any observations which are greater than four standard deviations away from the mean longitude and latitude of the enumeration subdistrict are removed. Figure 17 shows an example of this process. In 1921, where I have CSD polygons, I remove any geolocations which are greater than 3 kilometers from the edge of their CSD polygon. The remaining addresses I consider to be the exact location, as they correspond to a single section of land.

9. For example the enumerators instructions in 1906 advise *In a township, parish or other country district, where the houses are scattered, it is advisable to start on a road or highway at the border line of the district and visit in succession every occupied house until the other side of the district is reached, when the next road may be taken in the same way, and so on until the whole area assigned to the enumerator is covered, taking care to finish the census of one farm or lot before proceeding to the next.* (Government of Canada 1906)

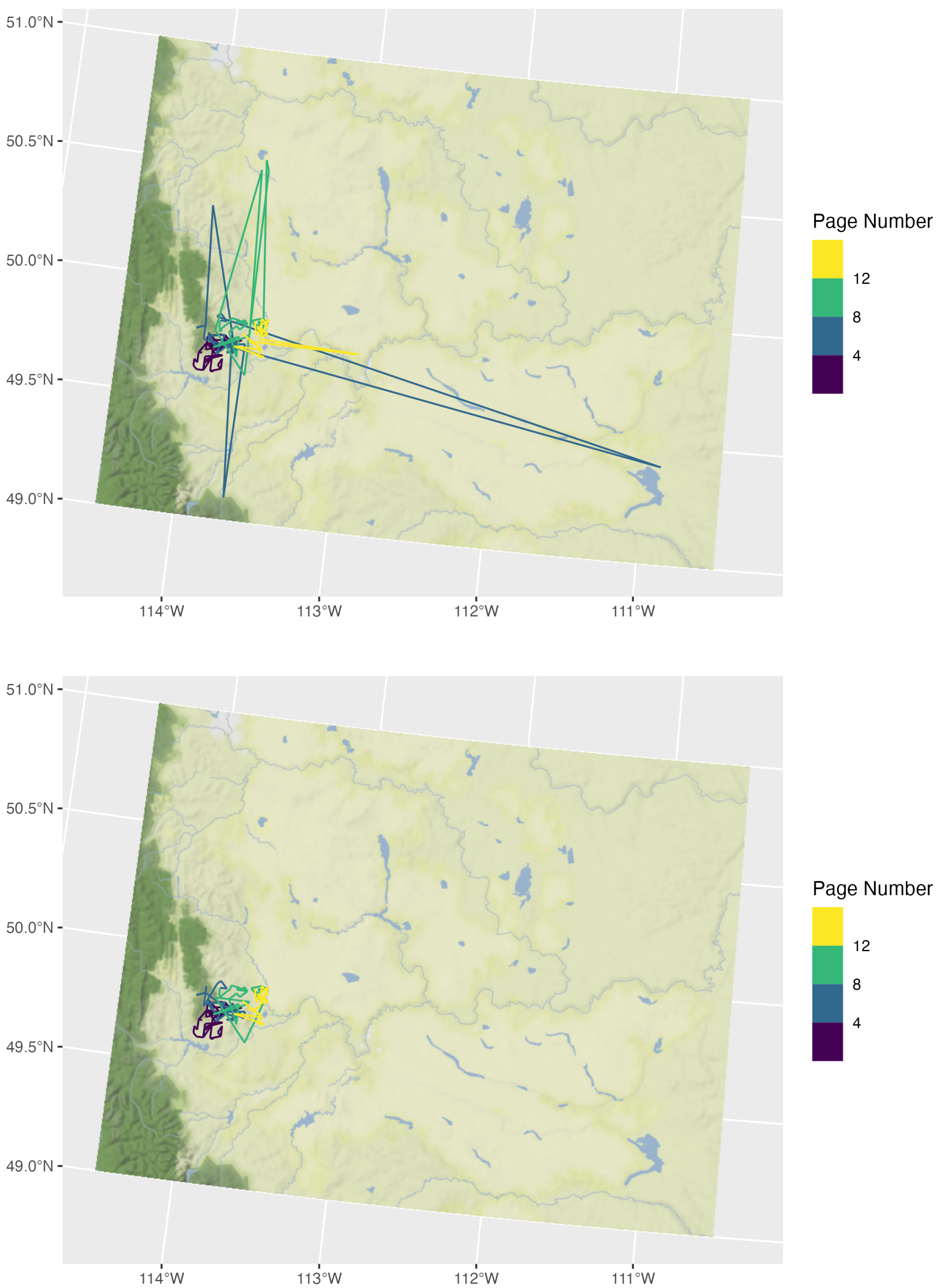


Figure 17: Enumeration path for a single enumeration subdistrict, before and after the cleaning proceedure is applied. Any location which is further than four standard deviations in either longitude or latitude from the centre of the enumeration subdistrict is removed.

For any addresses that remain unlocated I do a second round of locating to the nearest township, then a third round of locating to the nearest city. In 1921 there a several small towns which have an area close to that of a section. If the area of the CSD is less than 1.5 square miles (relative to a section which has an area of 1 square mile), then I consider the location to also be exact.

7.7.2 Creating Synthetic CSDs

In complete census years (1901, 1911, and 1921) CSD boundaries and centroids have been digitized by the HGIS lab at the University of Saskatchewan (HGIS Lab, n.d.). For census of the prairie provinces and the most recent complete census year (1906, 1916, 1926, and 1931) CSDs have not been digitized. To overcome this challenge I create synthetic CSDs using the enumeration subdistricts and the location of known households.

I first take the known locations from geolocated households, and then compute the centroid of those locations. I use this centroid if there are at least (number of households) located in that enumeration subdistrict. This gives the centroid of the synthetic CSD when the CSD is unknown for (A number) of enumeration districts out of a total of (Another number). For the remaining (A number) enumeration subdistricts I use the centroid of the enumeration district as the centroid of the enumeration subdistrict. This leaves only two enumeration subdistricts in northern Alberta and Saskatchewan which I geocode to an approximate location.

7.7.3 Geolocating Schools

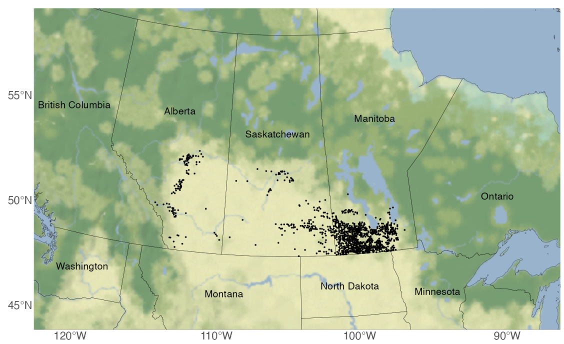
I implement two proceedures to geolocate schools.

For Alberta and Saskatchewan, I know the legal land description for each school, and use this to get the parcel of land that corresponds to that description. I start with the finest possible geography, the Quarter Section, and try to match each school. The remaining schools I attempt to match at the section level, and any remaining after that I match at the township level. As shown in table 18 there are cases where a school only has location information at the township level, will multiple possible townships reflecting the entire area of the school division. To resolve this I take the centroid of a group of townships as the location of the school.

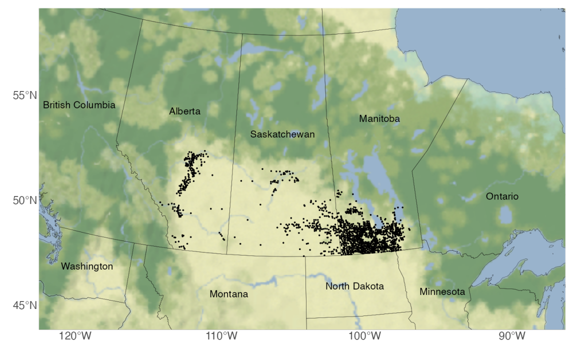
For Manitoba, where I already have longitude and latitude, I use the existing coordinates to retrieve the legal land description of the location of the school. I include this information in my school database for possible use in later regressions.

The bottom rows of table 20 show the number of schools I am able to geolocate in 1911. For both Alberta and Manitoba I am able to geolocate nearly all schools reported, while in Saskatchewan I am only able to geolocate 93% of schools. When I focus on the schools I am able to geolocate most precisely, at the section level, I find I'm able to geolocate 93% of schools in Alberta, 99% in Manitoba, but only 43% in Saskatchewan. As a result I show that the results are robust regardless of the school locations used in Saskatchewan.

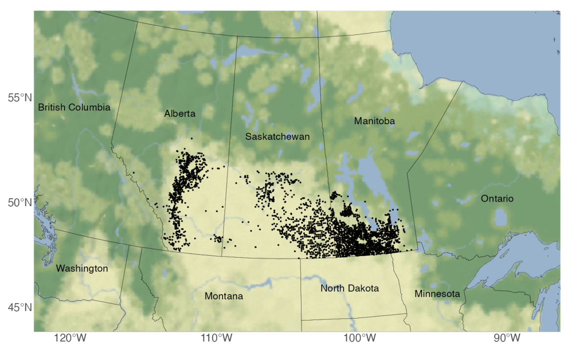
Figure 18 shows the expansion of school across western Canada from 1895 to 1910. Although schools were initially formed around Winnipeg in Manitoba, westward expansion



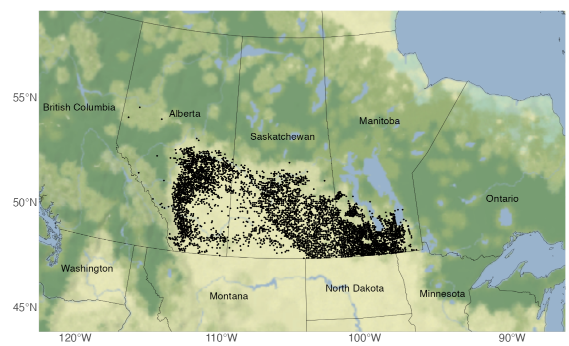
(a) 1895



(b) 1900



(c) 1905



(d) 1910

Figure 18: Expansion of schools in western Canada from 1895 to 1910.

led settlers to move further west, and construct schools. As a result we see the expansion of schools in Saskatchewan and Alberta (also seen in figure 16).

7.7.4 Farm Size Estimation

For the census waves in 1906, 1921, and 1931, I can observe the exact geolocations but have no information on land holdings. Instead I can estimate the farm size by taking the set of geolocations and estimating the set of Voronoi polygons around the geolocations. Voronoi polygons are computed from a set of points on a plane, where the plane is separated into regions based on which point is closest. Doing this for the set of households, gives an estimate of the amount of land surrounding an individual geolocated household. A small number of farms will be at the edge of the computed Voronoi polygons and will have a size defined by an arbitrary computational boundary. Farms at the edge are dropped from the sample.

The geolocation proceedure geolocates households to the nearest land section. In practice there can be up to four occupied quarter sections within a given land section, leading to multiple houses sharing the same geolocation. In the case where multiple households share the same geolocation, the area of the farm is divided by the number of households sharing that location.

To validate the estimated farm size I regress estimated farm size on the characteristics of the head of household recorded in the census. Table 21 presents these results for 1906, 1921, and 1931. 1906 is the most informative year as the census also recorded livestock holdings. I find that the estimated size of a farm positively correlates with the number of horses and cattle that the household has, and negatively correlates with the number of hogs. This is expected as the space requirements for hogs are significantly lower than for cattle or horses.

Expanding to 1921 and 1931 in columns 2-5 shows some common patterns with 1906. I find a consistently positive correlation with the number of adult males in a household, consistent with male farm labour being valuable. There is a strongly negative correlation with the household being located on a homestead section of land. Homestead sections were typically split between more owners and had a higher population density as seen in figure 2, as well as in the population values by section in figure 13. There is no consistent pattern for different levels of agricultural productivity.

The 1921 and 1931 census also include information on occupations and income. Column's 2-5 show that being an employer is associated with having a larger farm, consistent with being a landowner with hired help. Individuals listed as employees are shown to have 20% smaller farms. In each case the omitted category is being on Own Account, the typical category for independant farmers. Columns 3 and 5 include income as a covariate, showing that higher incomes are generally associated with smaller farms.

7.8 Additional Results

7.8.1 Distance to School

I compute distance to school in 1911 taking the set of geolocations from 1906 and computing the distance to the nearest school open in 1910. Using the 1910 distances instead of 1911 reflects that the 1911 census asked for the months at school in 1910 (Canada. Census and

Table 21: Farm Size Validation

Dependent Variable:	Ln Farm Area				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	1906	1921		1931	
Asinh Horses	0.0606***				
	(0.0052)				
Asinh Milk Cows	0.0015				
	(0.0055)				
Asinh Hogs	-0.0124***				
	(0.0040)				
Asinh Cattle	0.0229***				
	(0.0034)				
Asinh Sheep	-0.0027				
	(0.0063)				
Family Size	-0.0007	-0.0036***	-0.0031	0.0023***	0.0017
	(0.0019)	(0.0008)	(0.0021)	(0.0008)	(0.0022)
Fam. Adult Males	0.0234***	0.0131***	0.0142**	0.0252***	0.0162***
	(0.0043)	(0.0024)	(0.0058)	(0.0027)	(0.0051)
Homestead	-0.3010***	-0.1785***	-0.1636***	-0.1529***	-0.1324***
	(0.0185)	(0.0067)	(0.0180)	(0.0062)	(0.0137)
Asinh Wheat	-0.1594	-0.3176***	-0.3648*	-0.1152	-0.0621
	(0.1284)	(0.0699)	(0.2144)	(0.0808)	(0.1945)
Asinh Oats	0.3309*	0.0435	0.5829	-0.2737	-0.3143
	(0.1804)	(0.1850)	(0.5406)	(0.1727)	(0.3072)
Asinh Grass	0.0190	-0.0326	-0.0202	0.1199	0.1430*
	(0.0218)	(0.0199)	(0.0300)	(0.0763)	(0.0755)
Asinh Flax	-0.0159	-0.0064	0.0144	-0.1160	-0.0575
	(0.0559)	(0.0306)	(0.0291)	(0.0872)	(0.0924)
Asinh Barley	-0.2379	0.2689	-0.2563	0.3547**	0.3551
	(0.1613)	(0.1678)	(0.4808)	(0.1439)	(0.2614)
Employer		0.0544***	0.0249	0.0243***	0.0122
		(0.0105)	(0.0254)	(0.0048)	(0.0134)
Employee		-0.2150***	-0.2009***	-0.2013***	-0.2306***
		(0.0120)	(0.0267)	(0.0107)	(0.0166)
Log Income			-0.0180***		-0.0248***
			(0.0065)		(0.0082)
Enum. Sub.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	100,562	217,269	29,211	195,664	32,303
R^2	0.21181	0.16214	0.29698	0.18517	0.29221

Clustered (Enum. Sub.) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Regressing estimated farm size from Voronoi polygons on covariates at the individual level. Column 1 gives the results for 1906, columns 2-3 for 1921, and columns 4-5 for 1931. Columns 3 and 5 restrict to household heads who earned some income.

Statistics Office. 1911). Lagging the set of schools by a year also reflects that fact that school opening dates measured reflect the establishment dates of the district, not necessarily the construction date of the school. The median school distance in 1910 is approximately 2.9km, with a significant spread as seen in figure 19.

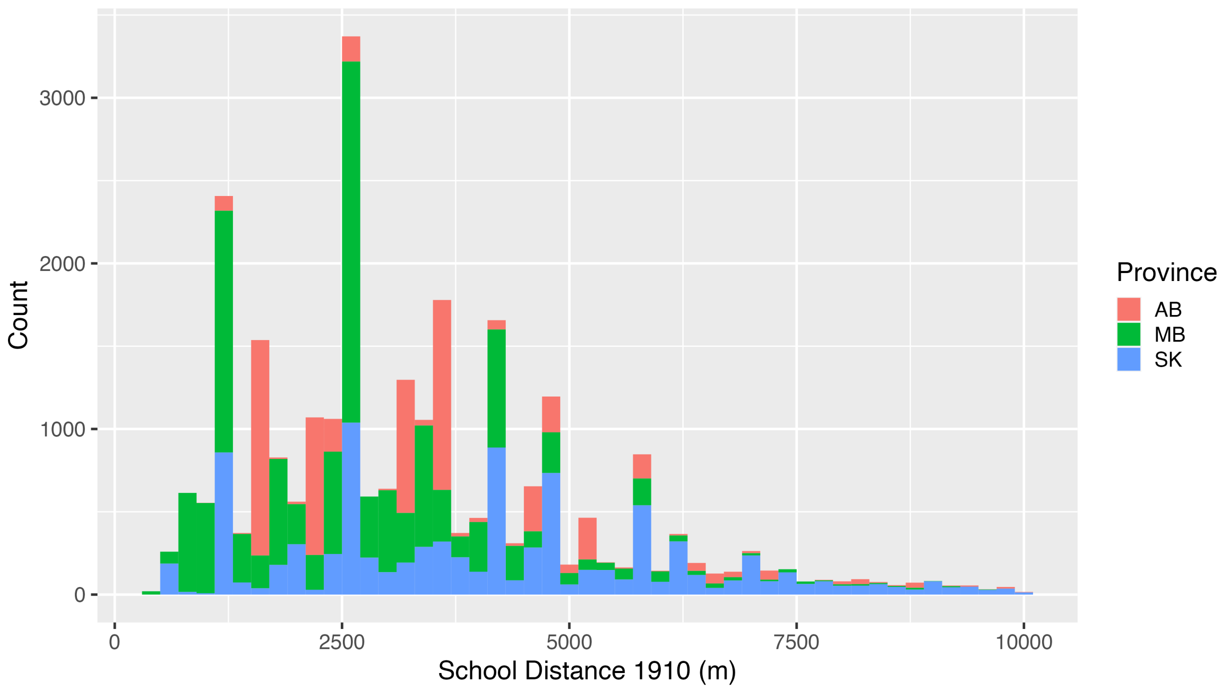


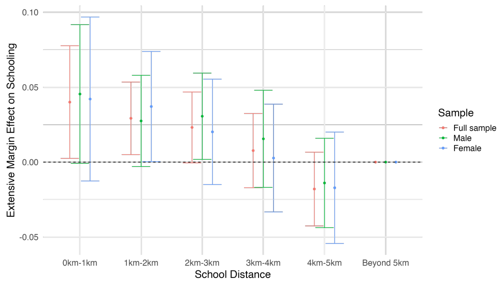
Figure 19: Distance to school for children in 1910, based on 1906 locations and restricting the sample to those that have not moved. Note the distribution has distinctive peaks including those at approximately 1250m and 2500m. This reflects the precision of the geolocation, with 0.75 miles being 1207m, and 1.5 miles being 2.41km.

The sample is restricted to children whose Census Subdivisions (CSD) are within 100km of each other between 1906 and 1911, to capture children who have likely not moved in the intervening five year period. CSD boundaries changed significantly between census waves due to population changes, making a high threshold necessary. The sample is further restricted to those that are at least five years old in 1911 (so they are guaranteed to be alive in 1906) and are less than eighteen years old in 1911, or the time that modern secondary schooling ends. The sample is further restricted to those that are listed as a descendant of the head of household in 1911. This restricts the sample to children who are living with their parents, and drops those who may have already moved away for work or higher schooling in 1911.

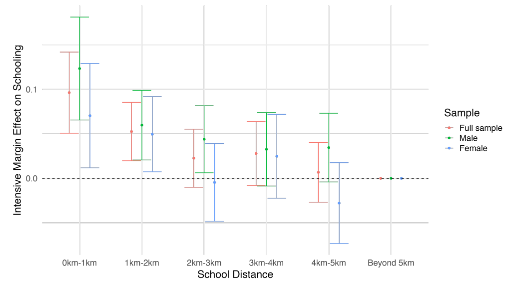
7.8.2 Intensive and Extensive Margin and Distance

Figure 20a gives the estimation results repeating the estimation in figure 3, but examining the extensive margin of school attendance only. Figure 20b also repeats the same estimation strategy, but dropping observations with zero attendance to examine intensive margin effects of school attendance. In both cases there is a clear decay pattern over distance, although the estimates are less precise than the main effect.

Figure 20: Intensive and Extensive Margin of School Attendance Over Distance



(a) School Attendance (Extensive Margin)



(b) Months of Schooling (Intensive Margin)

Extensive and intensive margin effects of distance on schooling in 1911, in 1km bins. All coefficients are expressed relative to the furthest bin of 5km or more. Includes controls for the interactions of sex, age, and birth order, birthplace, family livestock holdings, estimated agricultural productivity, whether the family lives on a homestead parcel of land, estimated farm size in 1906, and distance to the railway in 1911.

The average child who is within 1km of a school is approximately 5 percentage points more likely to have attended school in 1911 relative to a child who is further than 5km from a school. The mean school attendance for all children is 61.5%, so a decline of 6 percentage points is a significant determinant of school attendance. The intensive margin gives a difference of approximately 0.55 months of schooling for a child who is within 1km of a school compared to a child who is more than 5km away. The intensive margin appears to decay faster in space relative to the main effect, with the effects rapidly approaching zero in the 2-3km bin.

Comparing the intensive margin effects to the total effects show in figure 3, I find that the main effect of distance is a 15% decline in schooling versus a 9% decline from the intensive margin. The extensive margin effect is therefore 6% of the decline in schooling.

7.8.3 Sex

A descriptive feature emphasized in the school board reports in section 7.1 is that boys stay in school only until they have reached puberty and their labor becomes more valuable. To test if this is quantitatively meaningful I examine differences in school attendance for boys versus girls before and after the age of 13, when puberty typically occurs. I first estimate the difference in school attendance between girls and boys with the following specification:

$$y_{ig} = \beta sex_i \times age_i + sex_i + age_i + X_i\alpha_g + \epsilon_{ig} \tag{5}$$

where sex_i is a binary variable with 0 for female and 1 for male, age_i is an age fixed effect for all ages between 6 and 17, and X_i is a series of other controls including the distance to the nearest railway line in 1911, the distance to the nearest school, birthplace, birth order, and whether or not they family lives on homestead land, and α_g is the enumeration subdistrict.

Table 22: Attendance vs Distance

Dependent Variable:	Attends School 1911					
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Log School Distance	-0.0260***	-0.0251***	-0.0262***	-0.0258***	-0.0254***	-0.0253***
	(0.0062)	(0.0062)	(0.0062)	(0.0062)	(0.0061)	(0.0061)
Link Prob.	0.0482**	0.0472**	0.0463**	0.0362*	0.0321	0.0320
	(0.0207)	(0.0206)	(0.0207)	(0.0205)	(0.0204)	(0.0204)
Log RR Distance		-0.0076**	-0.0080***	-0.0077***	-0.0083***	-0.0080***
		(0.0030)	(0.0030)	(0.0030)	(0.0029)	(0.0030)
Log Farm Area			0.0089**	0.0080**	0.0051	0.0050
			(0.0038)	(0.0038)	(0.0039)	(0.0039)
Sex/Age/BO Interactions	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Enumeration Subdistrict	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birthplace				Yes	Yes	Yes
Homestead					Yes	Yes
Livestock					Yes	Yes
Ag. Productive.						Yes
Observations	26,878	26,878	26,878	26,878	26,878	26,878
R^2	0.36958	0.36981	0.37001	0.37277	0.37438	0.37518

Clustered (Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Estimates of the effect of distance to school on school attendance in percentage points. Includes controls for the interactions of sex, age, and birth order, enumeration subdistrict, birthplace, whether the family lives on a homestead parcel of land, family livestock holdings, estimated agricultural productivity, estimated farm size in 1906, distance to the railway in 1911, and the likelihood of a link being correct. All observations weighted by the link probability.

Table 23: Months of School vs Distance

Dependent Variable:	Log Months School 1911					
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Log School Distance	-0.0391***	-0.0390***	-0.0390***	-0.0395***	-0.0378***	-0.0362***
	(0.0075)	(0.0075)	(0.0075)	(0.0075)	(0.0075)	(0.0075)
Link Prob.	0.0561*	0.0556*	0.0556*	0.0541*	0.0490*	0.0466
	(0.0293)	(0.0293)	(0.0293)	(0.0291)	(0.0292)	(0.0291)
Log RR Distance		-0.0032	-0.0032	-0.0033	-0.0039	-0.0047
		(0.0034)	(0.0034)	(0.0034)	(0.0033)	(0.0033)
Log Farm Area		0.0027	0.0027	0.0024	-0.0003	-0.0006
		(0.0044)	(0.0044)	(0.0044)	(0.0045)	(0.0045)
Sex/Age/BO Interactions	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Enumeration Subdistrict	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birthplace				Yes	Yes	Yes
Homestead					Yes	Yes
Livestock					Yes	Yes
Ag. Productive.						Yes
Observations	16,816	16,816	16,816	16,816	16,816	16,816
R^2	0.31302	0.31309	0.31309	0.31498	0.31885	0.32006

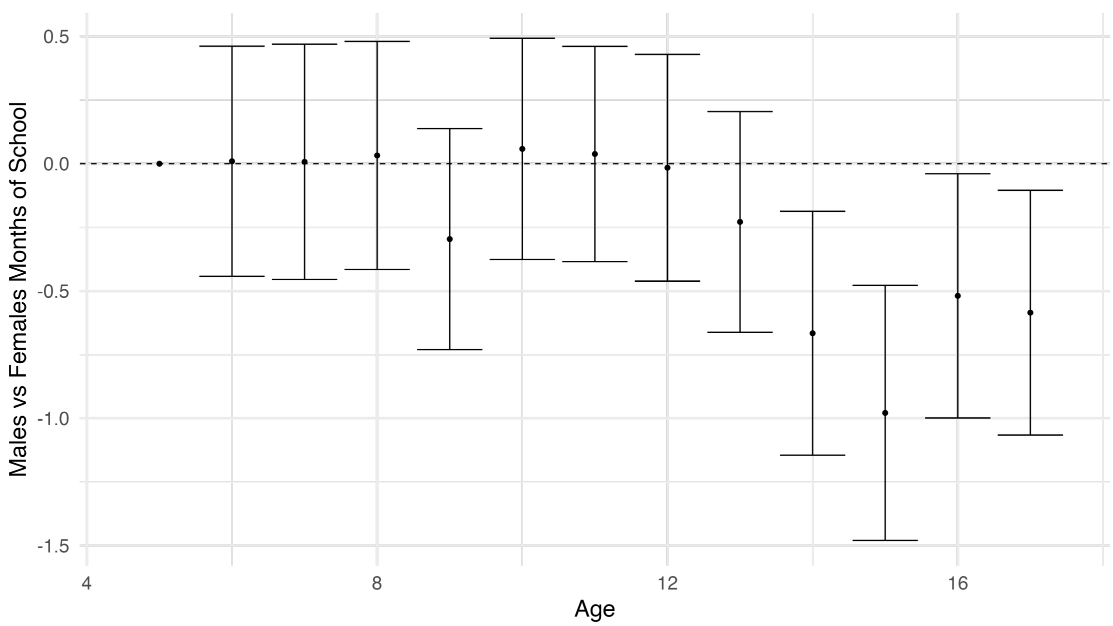
Clustered (Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Estimates of the effect of distance to school on months in school in 1911, expressed in logs. Includes controls for the interactions of sex, age, and birth order, enumeration subdistrict, birthplace, whether the family lives on a homestead parcel of land, family livestock holdings, estimated agricultural productivity, estimated farm size in 1906, distance to the railway in 1911, and the likelihood of a link being correct. All observations weighted by the link probability.

As in the previous section I use both the whether a child attended school in 1911 and the number of months they attended school in 1911 as outcome variables.

Figure 21 shows the coefficients of the interaction terms between sex_i and age_i from ages 6 to 17. As described in the school board reports there is a clear decline in male school attendance relative to females starting at age 13. The difference becomes significant and large by the late teens, amounting to approximately 0.75 months of school in a year, or three weeks. The average school attendance for children between the ages of 13 to 17 is 4.2 months, so a decline of 0.75 months represents a 17% decline in the amount of schooling attended.

Figure 21: Males vs Females



Coefficients of the interaction term of sex and age regressed on total months at school. Controls for sex, age, birth order, birthplace, enumeration subdistrict (geography), and whether the family is living on a homestead. The decline in the coefficients represents females attending more school relative to males.

Figure 22 shows that this result is primarily driven on the intensive margin. Boys decrease their likelihood of going to school only slightly relative to girls, but conditional on going to school decrease the amount that they go. This is consistent with boys remaining attached to the school, but being more selective about which days of school are attended as the value of their farm labor increases.

I then repeat the estimation in equation 5, but use an indicator for being over the age of 12 (13-17) to capture the effect on boys of puberty. The main result is in column 3, of table 24 where I find a coefficient of -0.6580 on the months of school for boys when over the age of 12, in line with the results in figure 21. I then vary the fixed effects used in the estimation. Column 2 drops the enumeration subdistrict fixed effect, and column 1 drops the homestead fixed effect. In each case I find negligible changes in the interaction effect between

Table 24: Months of School vs Age by Sex

Dependent Variable:	Months School 1911				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Male	0.0895	0.0852	0.0974	0.1004*	0.1008*
	(0.0602)	(0.0601)	(0.0597)	(0.0598)	(0.0602)
Older 12	-0.7744***	-0.8683***	-0.9518***	-0.9531***	-1.345***
	(0.0933)	(0.0937)	(0.0930)	(0.0932)	(0.0994)
Log RR Distance	-0.0818***	-0.0823***	-0.0905***	-0.0910***	
	(0.0290)	(0.0293)	(0.0290)	(0.0291)	
Log School Distance	-0.3392***	-0.3330***	-0.3235***	-0.3183***	
	(0.0621)	(0.0619)	(0.0614)	(0.0619)	
Log Farm Area	0.0501	0.0457	0.0005	-0.0006	
	(0.0376)	(0.0377)	(0.0383)	(0.0384)	
Link Prob.	0.7864***	0.7305***	0.6549***	0.6454***	0.3252
	(0.1774)	(0.1778)	(0.1763)	(0.1759)	(0.2204)
Male × Older 12	-0.6921***	-0.6893***	-0.6916***	-0.6914***	-0.7329***
	(0.1073)	(0.1072)	(0.1073)	(0.1074)	(0.1208)
Birth Order	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Enumeration Subdistrict	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	
Birthplace		Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Family					Yes
Homestead			Yes	Yes	
Livestock			Yes	Yes	
Ag. Productive.				Yes	
Observations	26,878	26,878	26,878	26,878	26,878
R^2	0.24081	0.24483	0.24966	0.25051	0.68260

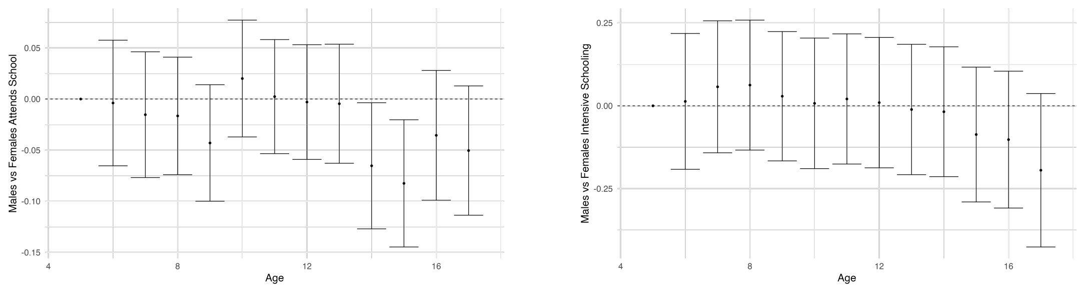
Clustered (Enumeration Subdistrict) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Months of school in 1911 versus sex interacted with age. Column 1 reports the regression without any family characteristics. Column 2 include whether the family lives on a homestead parcel. Column 3 includes enumeration subdistrict fixed effects. Column 4 includes family fixed effects. In each case the coefficient on sex interacted with being older than 12 is nearly identical, indicating that boys decrease their schooling after the age of 12.

sex and being over 12. Column 4 does the opposite, and adds a family fixed effect. The interpretation of this regression is that any changes in male school attendance over the age of 12 are relative to their siblings. Comfortingly I find coefficients that are nearly identical.

These results are unsurprising, and mirror what is report in the Iowa state census in 1915 as reported in Goldin and Katz (2000), that the total stock of education for women was higher than men. A related result from goldin2000 is that the returns to education for women were only significant until the point they were qualified to become a teacher or clerk as adults, and essentially zero aftewords. This suggests that the causal impact of education access may be to drive women towards those occupations, but this remains an area to be further researched.

Figure 22: Intensive and Extensive Margin of School Attendance for Boys vs Girls



(a) School Attendance (Extensive Margin) (b) Months of Schooling (Intensive Margin)

Coefficients of the interaction term of sex and age regressed on whether or not a child attended school in 1911 and the months of school attended in 1911. Controls for sex, age, birth order, birthplace, enumeration subdistrict (geography), and whether the family is living on a homestead. The decline in the coefficients represents females attending more school relative to males.

7.9 Difference in Differences Robustness

7.10 Farming Income

The 1931 census asked enumerators to record the income of employees only, and did not ask enumerators to record the income of those listed as employers or working on their own account. Some records for employers and own account workers do contain income, likely reflecting some enumerators asking everyone regardless of employment status. We can use this information to have a rough approximation of farmer incomes for non-employee farmers.

Table 29 breaks out farmer income by employment status. There are two possible ways that a farmer could be coded in the data, as either a farmer or as a labourer working on a farm. All six possibilities are listed. Incomes are highest for both Farmer's and Labourer's listed as employers at over $800 per year, with declines to approximately $500 per year if listed as on their own account. Employees are the lowest paid, with an income of only approximately $350.

Table 25: Splitting Farm work by Distance to Railway

Dependent Variable:	Farm Work		
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)
	Full Sample	Within 5km of Railway	Beyond 5km of Railway
School Constr. × Cohort	-0.0287*	0.0336	-0.0517**
	(0.0170)	(0.0376)	(0.0208)
School Constr.	0.0008	-0.0108	0.0099
	(0.0176)	(0.0395)	(0.0196)
Cohort	0.0078	-0.0115	0.0181
	(0.0098)	(0.0144)	(0.0137)
Link Prob.	0.4596***	0.4042***	0.4995***
	(0.0250)	(0.0426)	(0.0302)
Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fam. Bpl. + Homestead	Yes	Yes	Yes
Livestock + Ag.	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	14,701	5,299	9,402
R^2	0.09741	0.15705	0.11105
Dependent variable mean	0.62009	0.58464	0.64008

Clustered (Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Likelihood of working on a farm as an adult, split by if there is a railway within 5km. School construction is defined as 1 if the distance to school decreased by more than 5km between 1901 and 1906 in the baseline specification in column 3. All other columns alternate this value. The treated cohort is those who are 0-5 in 1906, as compared to those who are 12-17. Railway distance in the distance in 1906. Homestead is a control for the type of land parcel a family is on in 1906. Family birthplace are controls for own, father's and mother's birthplace. Livestock controls for family holdings of cattle, hogs, horses, milk cows, and sheep in 1906 as taken from the census. Agricultural conditions are for the agricultural productivity in wheat, oats, barley, flax, and reed canary grass. The link probability is a model derived probability of a link being correct from the MLP linking.

Table 26: Distance Robustness for Farm Work in 1931

Dependent Variable:	Farm Work				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	3km	4km	5km	6km	7km
School Constr. × Cohort	-0.0053	-0.0146	-0.0289*	-0.0229	-0.0219
	(0.0179)	(0.0167)	(0.0170)	(0.0170)	(0.0183)
School Constr.	-0.0058	-0.0091	0.0012	0.0077	0.0103
	(0.0161)	(0.0165)	(0.0174)	(0.0169)	(0.0180)
Cohort	0.0016	0.0038	0.0070	0.0055	0.0051
	(0.0099)	(0.0099)	(0.0098)	(0.0100)	(0.0099)
Log RR Distance (1906)	0.0203***	0.0204***	0.0204***	0.0205***	0.0204***
	(0.0047)	(0.0047)	(0.0047)	(0.0047)	(0.0047)
Link Prob.	0.4602***	0.4604***	0.4602***	0.4600***	0.4600***
	(0.0250)	(0.0249)	(0.0250)	(0.0250)	(0.0249)
Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fam. Bpl. + Homestead	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Livestock + Ag.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	14,701	14,701	14,701	14,701	14,701
R^2	0.09876	0.09888	0.09896	0.09882	0.09880
Dependent variable mean	0.62009	0.62009	0.62009	0.62009	0.62009

Clustered (Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Likelihood of being having at least one family member in agriculture as an adult in 1931. School construction is defined as 1 if the distance to school decreased by more than 5km between 1901 and 1906 in the baseline specification in column 3. All other columns alternate this value. The treated cohort is those who are 0-5 in 1906, as compared to those who are 12-17. Railway distance in the distance in 1906. Homestead is a control for the type of land parcel a family is on in 1906. Family birthplace are controls for own, father's and mother's birthplace. Livestock controls for family holdings of cattle, hogs, horses, milk cows, and sheep in 1906 as taken from the census. Agricultural conditions are for the agricultural productivity in wheat, oats, barley, flax, and reed canary grass. The link probability is a model derived probability of a link being correct from the MLP linking.

Table 27: Distance Robustness for Income in 1931

Dependent Variable:	Log Income				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	3km	4km	5km	6km	7km
School Constr. × Cohort	0.0968	0.0788	0.1188**	0.1307**	0.1335**
	(0.0600)	(0.0564)	(0.0597)	(0.0590)	(0.0633)
School Constr.	0.0191	0.0417	0.0071	-0.0220	-0.0080
	(0.0499)	(0.0518)	(0.0552)	(0.0568)	(0.0595)
Cohort	-0.2470***	-0.2455***	-0.2551***	-0.2580***	-0.2567***
	(0.0306)	(0.0311)	(0.0307)	(0.0306)	(0.0307)
Log RR Distance (1906)	-0.0334***	-0.0336***	-0.0337***	-0.0342***	-0.0342***
	(0.0125)	(0.0125)	(0.0125)	(0.0125)	(0.0126)
Link Prob.	-0.1970***	-0.1964***	-0.1961***	-0.1962***	-0.1964***
	(0.0629)	(0.0629)	(0.0629)	(0.0630)	(0.0629)
Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fam. Bpl. + Homestead	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Livestock + Ag.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	5,651	5,651	5,651	5,651	5,651
R^2	0.17419	0.17424	0.17437	0.17418	0.17431
Dependent variable mean	6.5234	6.5234	6.5234	6.5234	6.5234

Clustered (Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Income as an adult in 1931. School construction is defined as 1 if the distance to school decreased by more than 5km between 1901 and 1906 in the baseline specification in column 3. All other columns alternate this value. The treated cohort is those who are 0-5 in 1906, as compared to those who are 12-17. Railway distance in the distance in 1906. Homestead is a control for the type of land parcel a family is on in 1906. Family birthplace are controls for own, father's and mother's birthplace. Livestock controls for family holdings of cattle, hogs, horses, milk cows, and sheep in 1906 as taken from the census. Agricultural conditions are for the agricultural productivity in wheat, oats, barley, flax, and reed canary grass. The link probability is a model derived probability of a link being correct from the MLP linking.

Table 28: Family in Agriculture in 1931

Dependent Variable:	Family in Ag				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
School Constr. × Cohort	-0.0372**	-0.0279*	-0.0294*	-0.0305**	-0.0307**
	(0.0152)	(0.0155)	(0.0155)	(0.0155)	(0.0154)
School Constr.	0.0091	0.0037	0.0040	0.0016	0.0020
	(0.0164)	(0.0167)	(0.0166)	(0.0168)	(0.0166)
Cohort	0.0404***	0.0456***	0.0628***	0.0627***	0.0618***
	(0.0092)	(0.0095)	(0.0093)	(0.0093)	(0.0093)
Log RR Distance (1906)					0.0212***
					(0.0046)
Link Prob.	0.4448***	0.4307***	0.4194***	0.4183***	0.4190***
	(0.0246)	(0.0247)	(0.0246)	(0.0247)	(0.0246)
Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fam. Bpl.		Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Homestead			Yes	Yes	Yes
Livestock			Yes	Yes	Yes
Ag. Productive.				Yes	Yes
Observations	14,701	14,701	14,701	14,701	14,701
R^2	0.07935	0.08574	0.09609	0.09840	0.10026
Dependent variable mean	0.69322	0.69322	0.69322	0.69322	0.69322

Clustered (Enumeration Subdistrict (1906)) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Likelihood of being having at least one family member in agriculture as an adult in 1931. School construction is defined as 1 if the distance to school decreased by more than 5km between 1901 and 1906. The treated cohort is those who are 0-5 in 1906, as compared to those who are 12-17. Railway distance in the distance in 1906. Homestead is a control for the type of land parcel a family is on in 1906. Family birthplace are controls for own, father's and mother's birthplace. Livestock controls for family holdings of cattle, hogs, horses, milk cows, and sheep in 1906 as taken from the census. Agricultural conditions are for the agricultural productivity in wheat, oats, barley, flax, and reed canary grass. The link probability is a model derived probability of a link being correct from the MLP linking.

It is worth noting that these figures are sampled from a very small percentage of farmers. Of the total 1906-1931 sample only 4% of own account farmers reported any income.

Table 29: Estimated Farming Income by Type in 1931

Type	income_1931	has_income_1931	n
Farmer - Employer	$866.43	0.04	3812
Farmer - Own Account	$585.97	0.04	8363
Farmer - Employee	$381.53	0.68	1445
Labour - Employer	$927.46	0.39	33
Labour - Own Account	$318.75	0.18	44
Labour - Employee	$337.02	0.82	612

7.11 Growing up Rural vs Urban Managers

Table 30: Managers in 1931

Industry	n
Unknown	166
Bank	32
Lumber Mill	18
General Store	17
General Farm	14
Grain Elevator	12
Garage	10
Grocery Store	9
Insurance	9
General	8
Other	78

Grew up Rural

Industry	n
Unknown	198
General Store	23
Bank	20
Insurance	10
General	9
Grain Elevator	9
Steam Railway	9
Dairy Farm	8
Lumber Mill	8
Wholesale Grocery	8
Other	107

Grew up Urban